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LEAGUE OF WOMEN VOTERS[®]
OF SOUTH COUNTY

 **VOTER**

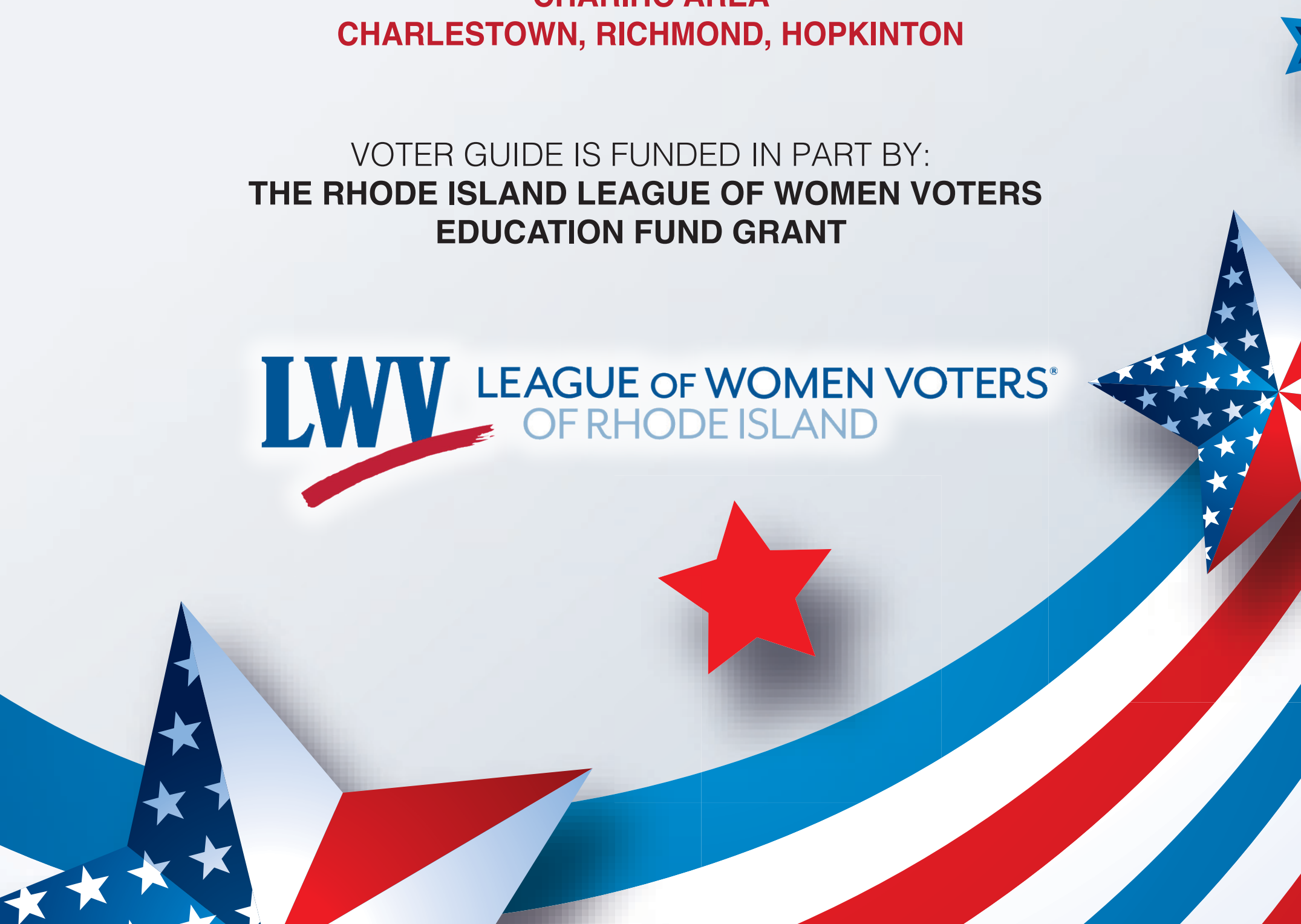
★★★ **GUIDE** ★★★

2026

COVERING:
CHARIHO AREA
CHARLESTOWN, RICHMOND, HOPKINTON

VOTER GUIDE IS FUNDED IN PART BY:
THE RHODE ISLAND LEAGUE OF WOMEN VOTERS
EDUCATION FUND GRANT

LWW LEAGUE OF WOMEN VOTERS[®]
OF RHODE ISLAND



2026 LIST OF CANDIDATES

STATE REPRESENTATIVES - Elect 1/District - 2 year terms

District 36 - New Shoreham, Charlestown, South Kingstown
TINA L. SPEARS - D (Incumbent) - uncontested - opted out

District 38 – Westerly, Charlestown, Hopkinton
BRIAN PATRICK KENNEDY – D (Incumbent) - uncontested - No Response

District 39 – Hopkinton, Richmond, Exeter
MEGAN L. COTTER – D (Incumbent)
JASMIN ROY – R - No Response

STATE SENATORS - Elect 1/District - 2 year terms

District 34 - Exeter, Richmond, Hopkinton, Charlestown, West Greenwich
ELAINE J. MORGAN - R (Incumbent) - No Response
SAMANTHA R. WILCOX - D

District 38 - Westerly, Charlestown, South Kingstown
VICTORIA GU - D (Incumbent)
WESTIN J. PLACE -R

TOWN OFFICES

CHARLESTOWN

Town Council - Two Year Term - vote for up to 5

DEBORAH A. CARNEY - D (Incumbent)
CYNTHIA M. DRUMMOND - D
JILL MARIE FONNEMANN - D
CRAIG T. MARR - R (Incumbent)
SASHA PUCHALSKI - I - No Response
STEPHEN J. STOKES - R (Incumbent)
BONNITA B. VAN SLYKE - I (Incumbent)
MATTHEW WESTOVER - R

School Committee - Four Year Term - vote for up to 3

HOLLY EAVES - D (Incumbent)
CRAIG F. LOUZON - D (Incumbent)
LINDA D. LYALL - D (Incumbent)
KIM M. COULTER - R - No Response
NICHOLAS TESTA - I - No Response

Non Partisan Planning Commission -
Top 2 serve six year terms, next 2 serve two year terms
as alternates - Vote for up to 4

COLEEN M. GALVIN YAROSHENKO - No Response
KATHERINE GINGRAS
CHERYL A. LILL - No Response
RUTH L. PLATNER
LAURA ANNE ROM
FRANCES M. TOPPING
GORDON S. WILLCOX

RICHMOND

Town Council - Two Year Term - vote for up to 5

DOUGLAS DESLAURIERS - D
PAUL ERDOS - R
DANIEL E. MADNICK - D
NORBERT L. MORIN - R
JAMES PALMISCIANO - D
JUSTIN K. PRICE - R
MARK T. REYNOLDS - D

School Committee - Four Year Term - vote for up to 2

PATRICK FARRELL - D
ANDREW A. MCCOY - D
DAVID LELLI - R

HOPKINTON

Town Council - Two Year Term - vote for up to 5

ROBERT BOUDREAU - R - No Response
ROBERT BURNS - R - No Response
MICHAEL JAMES GEARY - R - No Response
KEVIN G. LAMBERT - D
SCOTT SUTHERLAND - R - Opted Out
SYLVIA K. THOMPSON - I
RICHARD P WUCIK JR. - D

School Committee - Four Year Term - vote for 3

GREGORY J. AVEDISIAN - D
JUSTIN BENTLEY - D
CATHERINE M. GIUSTI - I
ROBERT THOMAS GREENE - R - No Response
EDWARD LOWE - R - (Incumbent) No Response
LARRY C. PHELPS - R - (Incumbent) Opted Out

Dear Readers,

The League of Women Voters is a nonpartisan political organization encouraging informed and active participation in government. We never support or oppose a political party or candidate. Our goal has always been to educate voters so that they may make informed choices when they enter the voting booth. By providing a Voter's Guide to your community, we hope that you learn more about the local candidates who are seeking offices and understand their positions more clearly.

Be informed before you vote! Check the RI Secretary of State's Office website to learn more and become familiar with the ballot you will see when voting. Most importantly VOTE!

Thank you to all the citizens who anonymously submitted questions for consideration. Thank you to all the LWVSC volunteers who contributed to this guide. Special thanks to all the candidates who responded in a timely manner with your answers.

This Voter Guide is paid for, in part, by a grant from the Rhode Island League of Women Voters Education Fund, a 501(c)3 entity, established by a generous donation from Susan B. Wilson, a past local LWVSC member.

Warmest regards,

Christine Martone

Christine Martone
President

Nina Rossomando

Nina Rossomando
Head, Voter Services

Nancy McLean

Nancy McLean
Project Lead

RI League of Women Voters, South County Chapter
www.lwvscri.org



Ballot Questions

Check your sample ballot for the details at <https://vote.sos.ri.gov/>

The League of Women Voters does not take a position on this or any ballot question, but provides the following information to help you vote your interests. Find more details about all state and town ballot questions in the 2026 Voter Information Guide from the RI Secretary of State Office that has been mailed to registered voters in Rhode Island.

State Ballot Questions

1. Higher Education Facilities - \$275,000,000
2. Housing and Homeownership - \$120,000,000
3. Economic Development - \$100,000,000
4. Cultural Economy - \$50,000,000
5. Green Economy Bonds - \$55,000,000

Local Ballot Questions

Town Name: **Charlestown**

6. Construction, Furnishing, and Equipping of Elementary School on Single Campus - \$116,000,000
- 7-10: Amendments to the Charlestown Home Rule Charter:
 7. Planning Commission
 8. Ordinances
 9. Purchasing
 10. Charter Revisions

Town Name: **Hopkinton**

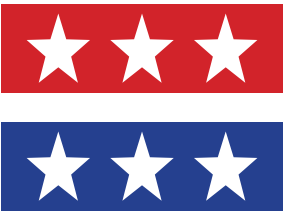
6. Construction, Furnishing, and Equipping of Elementary School on Single Campus - \$116,000,000
7. Charter Amendment - Town Clerk

Town Name: **Richmond**

6. Construction, Furnishing, and Equipping of Elementary School on Single Campus - \$116,000,000

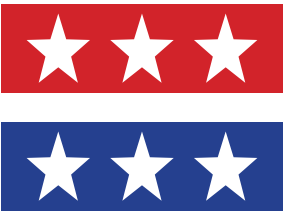
Local Ballot Questions - vary by town

Check your sample ballot for the details at <https://vote.sos.ri.gov/>



State of Rhode Island General Election Candidates

HOUSE OF REPRESENTATIVES



House District 39
Meghan Cotter
Democrat - Incumbent

1. Many residents feel that Rhode Island’s education funding formula needs reform. What would you recommend to the recently appointed Education Funding Commission?

I strongly supported creating a new legislative commission to take a comprehensive look at Rhode Island’s education funding formula. I had concerns about simply adopting the recommendations of the previous Blue Ribbon Commission because South County and regional school districts were not adequately represented in that process. Our communities face challenges that are very different from those of more densely populated districts, and they deserve a seat at the table.

My priorities are straightforward. First, the state needs to take greater responsibility for extraordinary special education costs. When one student requires extremely expensive services, a local school district and ultimately local property taxpayers should not be financially destabilized as a result. Rhode Island currently provides categorical funding for these

extraordinary costs, but reimbursements can be prorated when appropriations are insufficient.

Second, we need to address transportation. This is particularly important for large rural and regional districts, where buses travel significantly greater distances. Transportation is necessary to educate our children; it should be funded accordingly.

Finally, I believe Rhode Island should provide meaningful financial incentives for districts that voluntarily regionalize or share services. I have already introduced legislation aimed at strengthening those incentives. Regionalization will not work everywhere, but with declining enrollment and rising costs, communities willing to collaborate should have a reliable state partner.

2. What are your views on the 2nd amendment and gun legislation currently in place in RI?

I respect the Second Amendment and the constitutional rights of law-abiding Rhode Islanders. I also respect that people have deeply held concerns about gun violence and want government to take meaningful steps to keep their families and communities safe.

I voted against Rhode Island’s 2025 prohibited-firearms legislation. My concern was not a lack of concern for public safety. I questioned whether this particular approach would ultimately withstand constitutional scrutiny and whether Rhode Island taxpayers could be left paying the cost of prolonged litigation.

That concern is not hypothetical. Courts across the country continue to consider challenges involving restrictions on semiautomatic firearms, and the constitutional boundaries of these laws remain the subject of significant litigation. At the same time, courts have upheld some firearm restrictions, so I do not think it would be responsible to claim that Rhode Island’s law will definitely be overturned.

I believe we can protect constitutional rights while taking gun violence seriously. I will continue evaluating firearm legislation individually, based on whether it is constitutional, enforceable and likely to make Rhode Islanders safer.

My responsibility is to listen to those perspectives, examine the legislation carefully and cast the vote I believe best serves the people I represent.

3. Residents of RI are having increasing difficulty with access to affordable health care services. What are your specific ideas to improve this situation near and long-term?

Access to affordable health care is especially challenging in rural communities, and this has been one of my priorities since entering the General Assembly.

Early in my first term, I worked with Wood River Health and RIPTA to identify funding that enabled Wood River Health to secure a van to transport patients to medical appointments. Today, Wood River Health provides free van transportation to patients for medical and dental appointments. That work earned me the Rhode Island Health Center Association’s John H. Chafee Healthcare Leadership Award, but more importantly, it helped remove a very real barrier to care for our neighbors.

Transportation, however, is only one piece of the problem. Rhode Island also needs to ensure that reimbursement rates are competitive enough to attract and retain physicians, nurses, behavioral health professionals and other providers. We cannot expect providers to remain here if neighboring states consistently offer substantially better reimbursement and compensation.

In the near term, we should prioritize reimbursement increases in areas experiencing the greatest provider shortages and continue protecting community health centers and programs such as 340B that keep care accessible locally. I have worked across party lines on legislation aimed at protecting that program.

Long term, Rhode Island needs a sustainable reimbursement strategy that keeps providers here. Having insurance means very little if you cannot find a doctor who can see you.

4. What is your position with regard to the federal government trying to gain access to our voter rolls?

I support Secretary of State Gregg Amore’s decision to protect Rhode Islanders’ private voter information, and the federal court’s ruling affirmed that position.

I believe Rhode Island should maintain accurate voter rolls, conduct secure elections and comply fully with legitimate federal and state election laws. Secretary Amore’s office has an established voter-list maintenance process designed to keep Rhode Island’s rolls accurate.

5. The General Assembly has enacted a series of laws that increasingly preempt local zoning authority and require municipalities to accommodate additional residential density and development. How do you reconcile the impact and demand of these policies with the local infrastructure capacities in RI towns?

Rhode Island unquestionably needs more housing. But we also need to build responsibly. State housing policy cannot ignore the very real infrastructure limitations of rural communities.

That is particularly important in communities that depend on private wells, septic systems and groundwater rather than municipal water and sewer infrastructure. Increasing density without understanding an area’s water capacity can have long-term consequences for existing residents, future homeowners and the environment.

That is why I introduced legislation addressing groundwater protection and why I will chair the newly created legislative commission studying water-supply planning for new housing developments in Rhode Island’s rural communities. The commission was enacted in June 2026 specifically to examine how housing development can be balanced with safe and sustainable drinking-water supplies.

This should not be framed as a choice between protecting our environment and creating housing. We need to accomplish both.

I support increasing Rhode Island’s housing supply, but development needs to reflect the infrastructure of the community in which it is being built. Before requiring significantly greater density,

we should understand whether the water supply, wastewater systems, roads and other infrastructure can safely accommodate it.

Good housing policy is not simply about the number of units we build. It is about building homes in places and in ways that will remain sustainable for generations.

6. What differentiates you as a candidate and if elected, what will be your top priority during your term?

What differentiates me is a record of delivering tangible results for the communities I represent while working across party lines to get them done.

Early in my first term, I helped Wood River Health secure transportation funding through RIPTA for a patient transportation van, work that earned me the Rhode Island Health Center Association’s John H. Chafee Healthcare Leadership Award. I have also worked across party lines to protect the 340B program that community health centers depend upon.

I have made rural Rhode Island a priority at the State House. I chaired the Forest Management and Fire Prevention Commission, helped make the Green Bond greener by securing significant investments in forest management, and fought for \$50,000 to replace forestry hose that had not been replaced since the 1980s. I also introduced legislation to protect groundwater from overdevelopment and will chair a commission examining water capacity and housing development in rural communities.

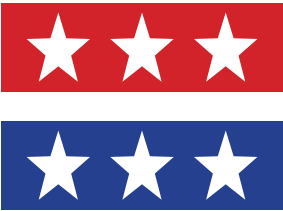
I have pushed for sustainable school funding and stronger incentives for regionalization and shared services.

My top priority remains making Rhode Island more affordable while protecting our quality of life. That means accessible health care, strong schools, responsible housing, lower utility costs, healthy forests, and reducing pressure on property taxpayers.

7. Y/N: Will you support legislation that strengthens and codifies voting rights in RI?

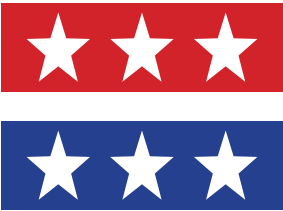
Yes

Tina L. Spears - D36 - opted out
Brian Patrick Kennedy - D38 - no response
Jasmin Roy - D39 - no response



State of Rhode Island General Election Candidates

SENATE



Senate District 34
Samantha R. Wilcox
Democrat

1. Many residents feel that Rhode Island’s education funding formula needs reform. What would you recommend to the recently appointed Education Funding Commission?

I recommend that the Education Funding Commission take a cautious, data-driven approach to reform. Rhode Island needs a funding formula that is simple, predictable, and equitable, but reform should not create new winners and losers among communities.

First, the newly appointed commission should update and validate the data before making changes. The Blue Ribbon Commission’s projections relied largely on 2024 data and did not fully account for the cost-sharing complexities of regional districts. The new Commission should use current information and publish district-by-district projections so taxpayers, municipalities, and school leaders understand the impact.

Second, the formula must account for the unique challenges facing rural and regional districts. The proposal did not consider the high transportation costs associated with serving a large geographic area. Property wealth alone does not capture the ability to pay more or the true

cost of educating students.

Districts facing funding reductions need a meaningful transition period. Communities should not be forced into spiked property taxes or sudden cuts to teachers, programs, or student services because of a formula change. A transition period would provide needed stability.

I believe we need to update the funding formula, but it should not be rushed. The goal should be a formula that is fair to students and taxpayers, recognizes differences among communities, and provides stability for responsible long-term planning.

2. What are your views on the 2nd amendment and gun legislation currently in place in RI?

I support the Second Amendment and our constitutional rights. In 2025, as Richmond Council President, I signed a resolution opposing the assault weapons ban. As a Senator, I will continue to support our constitutional rights and oppose legislation that unnecessarily infringes upon them. Additionally, I will support initiatives to assist with access to mental health services and keeping firearms out of the hands of those who pose a legitimate danger.

Our municipalities deserve a Senator who will listen to their concerns and support practical solutions. In 2026, the Hopkinton Town Council requested authorization to confer jurisdiction on the Hopkinton Municipal Court to hear certain appeals involving the return of firearms. Working with the Police Chief, the town sought a process allowing residents whose firearms were lawfully seized during an arrest, but subsequently deemed ineligible for return at the Chief’s sole discretion, to appeal that decision locally.

Allowing the Municipal Court to review these cases could provide a faster, less costly alternative to litigation while ensuring appropriate judicial oversight. The court is capable of evaluating the merits of the Police Chief’s decision. This change requires state authorization, but Hopkinton’s current Senator did not introduce the town’s requested legislation, preventing the proposal from receiving consideration in the Senate. As Senator, I will ensure our municipalities have a voice and that proposals receive the consideration they deserve.

3. Residents of RI are having increasing difficulty with access to affordable health care services. What are your specific ideas to improve this situation near and long-term?

I would approach health care affordability by lowering what Rhode Islanders pay for coverage and care, while expanding access to the providers they need. Too many families are facing higher premiums, deductibles, prescription costs, and difficulty finding timely primary or behavioral health care.

In the near term, I would focus on increasing transparency and competition. Rhode Islanders should be able to compare the actual cost of common procedures and services before receiving care.

We need to strengthen access to primary and behavioral health care. That means supporting community health centers, expanding the health care workforce, reducing unnecessary administrative burdens, and encouraging providers to practice in underserved and rural communities. Rhode Island has already taken steps to increase insurer investment in primary care, and I would build on those efforts while measuring whether they actually improve access and affordability. Insurance companies should not be providing medical care or advice and trusted providers should be able to give the care necessary without hurdles from insurance companies that do not want to pay.

Long term, we need to address the underlying drivers of health care costs rather than continually shifting those costs to patients. Supporting medical students and working to keep them in Rhode Island is essential. Affordability affects us all and Rhode Island needs to be an area that is affordable to live so that our health care professionals can live and work here.

4. What is your position with regard to the federal government trying to gain access to our voter rolls?

Elections are administered by the states, and voter registration is a state responsibility. I do not believe the federal government should have unrestricted access to Rhode Island’s voter rolls. Rhode Island should maintain control over its

voter registration data and determine how that information is collected, maintained, shared, and protected.

Our voter rolls contain sensitive personal information, and Rhode Islanders deserve confidence that their data will be handled securely and only for legitimate election-related purposes. I support cooperation with federal authorities when there is a clear, lawful, and necessary purpose, but that cooperation should not come at the expense of state authority or voter privacy.

As Senator, I will defend Rhode Island’s authority to administer its own elections and protect the integrity and security of our voter registration system.

5. The General Assembly has enacted a series of laws that increasingly preempt local zoning authority and require municipalities to accommodate additional residential density and development. How do you reconcile the impact and demand of these policies with the local infrastructure capacities in RI towns?

In 2024 and 2026, I voted in favor of Council resolutions affirming the importance of local authority over land use and housing decisions. I believe Rhode Island can pursue additional housing without undermining the ability of municipalities to responsibly plan for growth.

When the state requires development without adequately considering local infrastructure, the costs can fall on municipal taxpayers through increased demands on roads, schools, wastewater systems, drinking water, emergency services, and other public resources. Housing policy should not be separated from the infrastructure necessary to support it.

I support a collaborative approach that allows municipalities to retain authority to determine how goals can be achieved responsibly within their communities. State policy should also provide municipalities with the resources necessary to accommodate additional growth rather than simply shifting the costs to local taxpayers.

Our communities should have a meaningful voice in shaping their future. We can encourage housing development while protecting environmental resources, maintaining public safety, planning responsibly for infrastructure, and pre-

serving the ability of residents and local officials to make decisions that reflect the unique needs of their community.

6. What differentiates you as a candidate and if elected, what will be your top priority during your term?

What differentiates me as a candidate is my experience, independence, and commitment to listening to the people I represent. I was first elected to the Richmond Town Council in 2022 and reelected in 2024. During this time, I have worked to protect our environment, responsibly manage taxpayer dollars, support local businesses, increase government transparency, and strengthen civic engagement.

As Council President, I made accessibility and open government priorities, including holding open office hours so residents could share their concerns directly. I am proud of maintaining a level tax rate while protecting senior, 100% disabled, and farmland/open space exemptions; supporting critical infrastructure investments; creating a Small Business Grant program; and championing aquifer protection.

I have also demonstrated that I am willing to ask tough questions and stand alone when necessary. In 2023, I was the only Council member to oppose state level legislation that would have allowed tax stabilization agreements for the Preserve without voter approval. This was championed by our current state senator. I believe public officials must have the courage to stand up for taxpayers, even when it is politically difficult.

If elected State Senator, my top priority will be affordability and responsible government. I will work to make Rhode Island more affordable for families, demand transparency and accountability, protect our environment and water resources, and preserve the rural character of our communities.

Above all, I will listen, seek common ground, and represent all five towns of District 34 with honesty, independence, and integrity.

7. Y/N: Will you support legislation that strengthens and codifies voting rights in RI?

Yes

Elaine Morgan - D34 - no response



Be Sure to Vote on Tuesday, November 3, 2026.



Charlestown General Election Candidates

CHARLESTOWN TOWN COUNCIL



Deborah A. Carney
Democrat - Incumbent

1. What are your ideas for increasing affordable housing in Charlestown and how will you work to identify solutions?

One of the obstacles to constructing affordable housing in Charlestown is the high cost of the land. I will continue to work to identify land already owned by the town that could be used for housing. By partnering with organizations like Habitat for Humanity, we will be able to produce much needed housing. The town currently has approximately \$250,000 set aside for affordable housing. In addition, I will continue to support projects that rehab existing structures to be converted into year-round rental units. I was one of four current Town Councilors that supported

the recent proposal to overhaul a run-down motel into year-round housing. Not only does this produce housing, but it also beautifies a blighted building and surrounding grounds. I will work to increase affordable housing through an Inclusionary Zoning Ordinance. Inclusionary Zoning would incentivize developers to include affordable housing units in developments. When new developments are approved that don't include affordable housing, the town continues to move farther away from the state's mandate that each town have ten percent of housing that is affordable.

2. How do you think the new consolidated Chariho regional elementary school being located in Charlestown will impact the town?

If the electors from Charlestown, Richmond and Hopkinton approve the Chariho Unified Elementary School vote in November, I believe there will be some impacts to Charlestown. A positive outcome would be that Charlestown's children will remain in Charlestown, and their bus ride will not be any different than it is now. The building plan is for the construction of two new schools. One for Pre K - Grade 1, and the second for grades 2-5. This is not only a benefit for Charlestown's children, but for all three towns. The youngest students will be educated in a smaller building designed for their age, and the fifth-grade students will be returned to the elementary school. The increased traffic near the school could present challenges during dropoff and pickup times. The Town will need to maintain open communication with the Chariho School District to address any issues that may arise.

3. What role should tourism, recreation, and facilities such as Ninigret Park play in the town's future?

ation, and facilities such as Ninigret Park play in the town's future?

Charlestown relies heavily on tourism and recreation to sustain our businesses year-round. The town should continue to support our assets, which include our beaches, ponds, walking trails, and our parks. Over the past four years, the majority of the Town Council has worked cooperatively with organizations such as the South County Tourism Council to bring improvements to Ninigret Park. These include the Trolls from world renown artist Thomas Dambo, the new stone moon gate, the stone sea serpent, the daffodil trail, new trees and landscaping throughout Ninigret Park. The South County Tourism Council is also improving the entrance to Ninigret Park. The addition of the trolls has brought numerous visitors to Charlestown year-round. While here they support our local businesses. This is important for Charlestown to remain a vibrant community. Question #7 below asks for a "yes" or "no" response with regards to lighting in Ninigret Park. This is not a "Yes" or "No" question. There are too many undefined variables that would impact my answer. Variables such as, would these be permanent or portable lights? What are the "defined evening hours" referenced in the question? What type of recreational use? The list goes on. It is important to take all factors into consideration before answering the question.

4. What do you believe are the most important priorities when balancing economic development, environmental protection and rural character?

All three are equally important to keep Charlestown fiscally and environmentally healthy. I, along with those I am running with promise to continue to support local and small businesses while

providing opportunities for success. We promise to protect our rural community to ensure Charlestown remains a beautiful, rural community that grows in a balanced and responsible manner that comes with a commitment to keep the character of the town intact. I stand by the pledge. It is also important to be proactive to prohibit businesses that could be harmful to Charlestown, such as Battery Energy Storage Systems and Data Centers. I recently proposed the town consider an ordinance regarding Battery Energy Storage Systems, subsequently, the Town Council passed an ordinance prohibiting both in town.

5. What actions should Charlestown take regarding climate resilience and coastal preparedness?

Charlestown is already proactive about climate resilience and coastal preparedness. If re-elected, I will continue to be proactive. Charlestown has qualified staff who do a wonderful job of keeping the town prepared. The most recent example is the reconstruction of the western wall of the Charlestown Breachway. This was a massive undertaking, but through a true collaboration of town staff, our legislators, the state, and town officials, we were able to repair the breachway wall, maintain the health of the pond and restore the beach. In addition, the Town Council has supported funding pond and beach preservation. Another action I took while on the Town Council in 2021 was to vote to establish the Charlestown Climate Resiliency Commission. This group of highly qualified residents' studies and analyzes issues and impacts of climate change including storm surge, sea level rise, hurricanes, floods, wildfires, drought, deforestation and other weather-related events. They propose plans for mitiga-

tion of and adaptation to impacts from climate change.

6. What differentiates you as a candidate and if elected, what will be your top priority during your term?

What differentiates me is the twenty-four years of experience and knowledge I have brought to the Town Council. I was first elected to the Charlestown Town Council in 2002. Since then, I served ten years as Town Council President, and two years as Vice-President. I served four years on the Chariho Regional School Committee. In addition, while not serving on the Town Council or School Committee I volunteered for other Town boards and Committees, including the Charter Revision Advisory Committee and the Chariho Audit Sub Committee. I have proven that I do the work necessary to make informed decisions. I understand the Town's Home Rule Charter, our Ordinances, the State's Open Meetings Act, and related laws and regulations. If re-elected, my top priority will be to create workforce housing in Charlestown. For Charlestown to continue to be a vibrant community, we need young families. We need housing for those residents that want to down-size but remain in Charlestown. We need housing that is affordable. Charlestown is on a good path. I am respectfully asking for your vote to continue our positive momentum and to continue to work for all of Charlestown residents.

7. YES/NO: Do you think Ninigret Park should add lighting for recreational use during defined evening hours?

No response



Cynthia M. Drummond
Democrat

1. What are your ideas for increasing affordable housing in Charlestown and how will you work to identify solutions?

This is a serious concern throughout Rhode Island, but it has become evident that applying the same standards and solutions to every city and town in the state has not and will not produce the results everyone is hoping for. The 10% affordable housing goal is not as easily attainable for many smaller municipalities, such as Charlestown, which have neither the resources nor the public infrastructure to accommodate a major expansion of housing. Charlestown is currently just under 4%, less than half the 10% goal set by the state. A major concern in Charlestown centers on water, since the town is 100% dependent on private wells for its drinking water supply. In addition to private

drinking water wells, Charlestown, unlike the larger municipalities, does not have a sewer system, and depends on septic systems for waste treatment. The state now allows developers to exceed municipal zoning limits through a "density bonus" when some of the units are designated affordable. This higher density of market-rate housing can threaten our groundwater. I believe the time has come for a more bottom-up approach to the affordable housing issue in Rhode Island, and I would welcome the opportunity to work with the state to explore affordable housing initiatives that would take into account the needs and resources of towns like Charlestown.

2. How do you think the new consolidated Chariho regional elementary school being located in Charlestown will impact the town?

The new school will be built on land leased from the town. The town will not be responsible for maintenance and improvements to the building. In an Aug 4 referendum, Charlestown residents approved a proposal allowing the town to lease town-owned land to the Chariho Regional School District for a new, consolidated elementary school for children in grades K through 5 from the three Chariho towns. Having covered the Chariho schools for many years, I saw for myself how the district was having to spend taxpayer dollars to maintain and repair school buildings that were about 100 years old. I understand that many residents feel they are overburdened by taxes and have become resistant to funding improvements to school buildings, however, spending money on buildings that cannot meet the current standards set by the Rhode Island Department of Education doesn't make economic sense, particularly in light of state subsidies for new school construction. In addition, I think it's important to remember that people often move to towns

because of their schools, and they move away when the schools are substandard. This, in turn impacts our tax base. I would like to add, however, that care should be taken to mitigate the impact of increased vehicle traffic, particularly at drop-off and pickup times.

3.What role should tourism, recreation, and facilities such as Ninigret Park play in the town's future?

Our coastline and recreational opportunities have made Charlestown a major tourist destination. Ninigret Park, which hosts festivals, concerts and athletic events, now also draws visitors who come to see the trolls. I agree that for many, the park is probably what our town is known for, but Charlestown is recognized most often for its most important natural asset: its coastline. This is why people take vacations here and why some buy homes here. This is also what keeps our property taxes low and our lifestyle pleasant. I was interested to see how the town is perceived by non-residents, so I did a quick internet search that immediately brought up an AI description of the town's assets. The AI overview reads: "Charlestown, Rhode Island is a quiet seaside town known for its pristine golden-sand beaches, strict conservation lands, the Charlestown Breachway, and popular summer events like the Charlestown Seafod Festival." Other assets mentioned in the AI description are the Ninigret Park National Wildlife Refuge, the Frosty Drew Observatory and the Fantastic Umbrella Factory. While our recreational facilities attract tourists, most people come here for one reason: the beach. It is critically important during this time of unpredictable and extreme weather and sea level rise that the town do whatever it can to preserve the natural assets that make our town special.

4.What do you believe are the most important priorities when balancing economic development, environmental protection and rural character?

People do not come to Charlestown to make their fortunes. They do open businesses, many of which are dependent on tourism. They also move here because this is a peaceful, safe community with excellent public schools. Others move here when they retire. Whatever economic development initiatives are undertaken by the town, they must prioritize the protection of the most important economic drivers of all: our natural resources. If those are compromised by natural disasters or development, we will be like any other suburban town. We cannot control emerging threats such as sea level rise, but we can take steps to mitigate their impacts on our coastline.

5.What actions should Charlestown take regarding climate resilience and coastal preparedness?

Charlestown has been at the forefront of municipal climate change adaptation, and it is important that those efforts continue. Of course, there is only so much we can do as sea level rise continues eroding our shoreline, and saltwater seeps into drinking water wells. Our coastal ponds, among our most important economic assets, are also compromised by warming seas and runoff, including nitrogen, from surrounding development. Our Building and Zoning Official, GIS Coordinator and Onsite Wastewater Manager are among the officials who have been guiding the town as it adapts to the changes. Knowing that some of our coastal land has already been developed beyond carrying capacity (what the land can accommodate) makes it even more urgent to ensure that the actions the town takes will protect the fragile and compromised coastal ecosystem.

6.What differentiates you as a candidate and if elected, what will be your top priority during your term?

I have lived in Rhode Island for nearly 30 years. As a journalist in Canada, where I was born, (I am a U.S. citizen) I focused many of my stories on natural resource and environmental issues affecting rural and indigenous communities in northern Quebec. I spent more than 10 years working for the Westerly Sun after I moved here, covering Charlestown, Richmond, Hopkinton and the Chariho Regional School District. I believe this experience sets me apart, because I developed an understanding of the challenges towns face and how they resolve contentious issues. I covered countless municipal and Chariho budget meetings, and meetings of Town Councils, Planning Boards and Zoning Boards. I have watched council members and residents grapple with development threats, as solar companies elbowed their way into towns which had already said they would not approve commercial solar facilities but were worn down by persistent and well-funded corporations and their attorneys. I also hold a Master of Marine Affairs degree from the University of Rhode Island. This multidisciplinary program includes studies in ocean and coastal policy, ocean science, natural resource economics and ocean law. If elected, I will bring this knowledge to my work on the Town Council. My top priority would be to return control over development to the towns and require the state to be more collaborative.

7. YES/NO: Do you think Ninigret Park should add lighting for recreational al use during defined evening hours?

No



Jill Marie Fonnemann
Democrat

1. What are your ideas for increasing affordable housing in Charlestown and how will you work to identify solutions?

To increase affordable housing in Charlestown, my focus will be on finding balanced, localized solutions that respect

our unique environment. I will work to identify these options by collaborating directly with our Town planner, Town council, Affordable Housing Commission, Planning Commission, and residents to gather comprehensive data and explore smart zoning opportunities. My priority is ensuring that any new housing initiatives involve careful decision-making and adherence to regulations. This ensures we meet state mandates while protecting our precious natural resources, open spaces, and dark skies from negative environmental impacts.

2. How do you think the new consolidated Chariho regional elementary school being located in Charlestown will impact the town?

Hosting the proposed Chariho unified elementary campus in Charlestown will be a major transition for our community, which is why our priority must be gathering complete information to weigh the long-term regional benefits. A project of this scale requires thoughtful decision-making that balances the needs of incoming families with the protection of our current taxpayers. If elected, I will focus on helping to manage this impact by ensuring we maximize the shared regional funding available to best protect our local tax dollars.

3. What role should tourism, recreation, and facilities such as Ninigret Park play in the town's future?

ation, and facilities such as Ninigret Park play in the town's future?

We can utilize Ninigret Park to boost our economy by creating community focused initiatives that make the park a destination without turning it into an arena. Small community events can be organized with an educational approach, while contributing to our economy in our shoulder season and teaching the importance of our fragile ecosystem, native plants, and local wildlife. There is no reason to focus solely on summer events; guided winter tours and snowshoe treks are perfect examples of what is possible. South County Tourism has generously invested in our park, making it a destination for increased visitors who then support our small businesses. Let's keep up that momentum by investing in smart, sustainable park initiatives.

4. What do you believe are the most important priorities when balancing economic development, environmental protection and rural character?

I believe we can balance economic development with our town's needs through mindful planning, strategic decision-making, and strict adherence to environmental regulations. We must conserve our natural resources, open spaces, dark skies, and historic architecture while protecting our small-town character. Liv-

ing in one of our community's ten oldest houses built in 1732, I understand firsthand why preservation matters. Growth is inevitable, but to prevent irresponsible development and protect our town, we must stay informed and united. As a unique Rhode Island community, the only way forward is to come together and agree on a responsible, shared direction that preserves our heritage.

5. What actions should Charlestown take regarding climate resilience and coastal preparedness?

Climate resilience and coastal preparedness require continuous monitoring and well-informed, science-based decision-making. By collaborating closely with our existing environmental boards and commissions, we can support and expand our preservation efforts to maintain the health of our ecosystem. Protecting our waterways yields vital economic benefits: it directly supports our local oyster farmers and fishermen, prevents ecological decline, and safeguards the seasonal tourism that fuels our local shops and commerce.

6. What differentiates you as a candidate and if elected, what will be your top priority during your term?

Having served on the Parks and Recreation Commission for the past

3.5 years as well as the Ninigret Park Community Center Subcommittee, I offer an independent perspective. I am not a career politician, nor was I raised in a political setting, meaning I approach town business with open eyes, zero preconceptions, and a commitment to data-driven decisions. I ran in last December's special election, missing by just 42 votes—proving our town wants a fresh approach. During the campaign, I rejected the old habit of political hostility. While electioneering, I took photos alongside my opponents for social media to show our community that unity is possible. My decades-long background in the hospitality industry has uniquely prepared me for public service. My role as Beverage Director and Manager involves finding common ground, solving complex problems in real-time, and mediating differences. I have a history of uniting neighbors through fundraising efforts for residents in need. I will be the person who listens, encourages others to listen and stand up for what is right. Because of this I truly hope that I will be considered to be an even stronger voice for Charlestown.

7. YES/NO: Do you think Ninigret Park should add lighting for recreational al use during defined evening hours?

Yes



Be Sure to Vote on Tuesday, November 3, 2026.



Charlestown General Election Candidates

CHARLESTOWN TOWN COUNCIL



Craig T. Marr
Republican - Incumbent

1. What are your ideas for increasing affordable housing in Charlestown and how will you work to identify solutions?

I believe the Town should work with partners such as Habitat for Humanity and others to find creative and affordable solutions. The town needs to review the possibility of using any suitable properties it may already own to defray land costs.

2. How do you think the new consolidated Chariho regional elementary school being located in Charlestown will impact the town?

I believe it will create some traffic issues around the site of the school. I also think that Chariho should review the option of purchasing the 70+ acre

site of the turf farm abutting the Chariho campus as a better alternative now that the landowner has agreed to sell.

3. What role should tourism, recreation, and facilities such as Ninigret Park play in the town's future?

Tourism is one of the main economic drivers in Charlestown. The economic benefit of the visitors to the Trolls has been significant. So too are the festivals such as the Seafood festival, Rhythm and Roots and the Seaside Classic soccer tournament.

4. What do you believe are the most important priorities when balancing economic development, environmental protection and rural character?

Clearly the balance is important.

Charlestown lacks infrastructure such as sewer and town water so we need to be vigilant about protecting our water supply. At the same time, we need to be open to small business so that we create job opportunities especially for young people starting out in the workforce and for our many seniors that may need supplemental income. I emphasize small businesses to differentiate from large chains so that we maintain our rural character.

5. What actions should Charlestown take regarding climate resilience and coastal preparedness?

I think the town has a great working relationship with URI and CRMC whose research and monitoring of coastal changes and other environmental challenges helps guide our officials on neces-

sary actions and proactive safeguards.

6. What differentiates you as a candidate and if elected, what will be your top priority during your term?

As a local business owner and current member of the Town Council I am in constant contact with many residents. I listen to their concerns and suggestions and act with the best of my ability to represent their interests with reason, logic and fairness.

7. YES/NO: Do you think Ninigret Park should add lighting for recreational use during defined evening hours?

No response



Stephen J. Stokes
Republican - Incumbent

1. What are your ideas for increasing affordable housing in Charlestown and how will you work to identify solutions?

Affordable housing in Charlestown is already out of reach for many working families and individuals. The first step is being honest about what "affordable" actually means in our coastal market. Even units that qualify as affordable under state guidelines are often still too expensive for the people who need them most.

Let's prioritize rental units over for-sale housing when we invest limited affordable-housing dollars. Apartments create a renewable supply: when one household moves on, the unit remains available at the affordable rate for the next qualified resident. Homeownership programs, while valuable, lock up those scarce resources for decades and do little to address the ongoing shortage.

The reality is that rising coastal property values and continued market-rate

development will keep pushing the definition of "affordable" higher. This issue is already front and center in our discussions, and it will stay there until we identify approaches that are both realistic and sustainable for Charlestown.

As a Councilor, I will continue to press for practical, data-driven solutions—working with our planning staff, housing partners, and neighboring communities to evaluate what has worked elsewhere and what aligns with our Town's character and infrastructure capacity.

2. How do you think the new consolidated Chariho regional elementary school being located in Charlestown will impact the town?

I fully support building a unified elementary school. Our students deserve a modern facility that supports the best possible learning environment. I do have serious concerns about placing it in Charlestown and believe the main Chariho campus is the better location. The proposed Charlestown property has size and dimensional constraints that limit the school's layout and parking. There are unknown site factors, like ledge, that may drive up excavation costs, restrict design options, and add time to construction. It is also unclear whether the existing wells can reliably support a modern facility of this scale.

The current plan calls for two buildings constructed sequentially. Building costs will almost certainly rise over that timeline, and we face a five-year window to complete construction to secure full state reimbursement. Traffic impacts on the surrounding neighborhood are another real concern. Finally, Charlestown owns the existing school building; consolidating here means the Town loses that asset and its inherent value. Any short-term savings from avoiding a land purchase at the main campus are likely to be more than offset by higher excavation, construction, and design costs forced by the constraints of the Charlestown site. I believe the School Committee should consider relocating the project to the main campus.

While I absolutely support the new

school. I believe serious consideration and thought have to be at the forefront of the Charlestown location. If the project ultimately remains here, I will work to protect Charlestown's interests at every step.

3. What role should tourism, recreation, and facilities such as Ninigret Park play in the town's future?

Ninigret Park and related recreation should serve Charlestown residents first while supporting sustainable, character-compatible tourism.

The park is a valuable community asset with swimming, sports fields, playgrounds, disc golf, bike paths, and the Frosty Drew Observatory. These facilities must remain accessible and well-maintained for local families and visitors. Large events such as the Seafood Festival and Rhythm & Roots bring economic benefits. They should continue, but with a clear understanding of expectations, traffic management, and cost-recovery requirements to ensure they do not burden taxpayers or overwhelm our rural roads.

Tourism should emphasize experiences that fit Charlestown's identity: the Dambo trolls, public art, nature trails linked to the National Wildlife Refuge, paddling on the salt ponds, and stargazing. Partnerships with the South County Tourism Office for beautification and marketing help improve the park with external resources rather than relying solely on local tax dollars.

Beyond Ninigret, we should expand practical public access by improving boat ramps, better managing beach entry points, and ensuring responsible salt-pond access that supports fishing, kayaking, and swimming while protecting sensitive coastal resources.

Recreation and tourism can strengthen our economy and quality of life when managed responsibly. My priority remains keeping Charlestown beautiful, rural, and affordable for the people who live here.

4. What do you believe are the most important priorities when balancing

economic development, environmental protection and rural character?

Growth and development sustain a town's vitality, but they must be managed so new projects remain consistent with Charlestown's character. We should prioritize revitalizing poorly maintained and unused commercial properties before expanding further. Economic growth must stay cost-effective for taxpayers and environmentally sound. Projects that clash with the community's identity or are too commercial would be better suited to areas that have the infrastructure to support them; however, small businesses, coffee shops, and other charming, small-town commercial enterprises are welcome.

I support responsible development with clear restraints that protect the environment and our rural identity. At the same time, we must actively support existing local businesses and encourage new small enterprises that fit the community.

Keeping Charlestown beautiful, rural, and financially sustainable remains the priority.

5. What actions should Charlestown take regarding climate resilience and coastal preparedness?

Charlestown must continue practical, collaborative action to protect our coastline, salt ponds, and infrastructure while respecting taxpayer resources and our rural character.

We recently completed the long-term repair of the Charlestown Breachway in partnership with DEM and CRMC. The \$8.4 million project—funded with \$5 million from DEM/state sources, \$2 million from CRMC for dredging, and \$1.4 million from the Town—rebuild the west wall, dredged the channel, renourished the beach, and constructed storm-resilient dunes. This work restores safe navigation, improves water quality in Ninigret Pond, and strengthens the coastline against future storms.

The Town invests heavily in coastal resilience projects, including beach and

barrier protection, and hazard mitigation planning. Charlestown is one of the few communities in Rhode Island with a standing Climate Resiliency Commission. This body meets monthly to study sea-level rise, storm impacts, and adaptation strategies, then recommends concrete steps the Town can take.

In the future, we should prioritize maintaining critical infrastructure, securing external funding whenever possible, keeping the Hazard Mitigation Plan up to date, and protecting public access to beaches and ponds. Resilience efforts must remain cost-effective, science-based, and focused on results that safeguard both our environment and the quality of life for residents.

6. What differentiates you as a candidate and if elected, what will be your top priority during your term?

What differentiates me is my reputation for fairness and a genuine willingness to hear all sides of an issue. I make decisions based on facts and information rather than party or political affiliation. When new information comes to light, I am the first to acknowledge if I was wrong and adjust course. I work hard to understand every perspective and take all voices into account before reaching a conclusion.

If re-elected, my top priority will be to continue the solid work I have done over the past two terms on the Town Council. I will maintain the sound fiscal policies that have kept Charlestown well managed, well-funded, and operating with very low taxes. Responsible stewardship of taxpayer dollars remains essential to protecting our quality of life and rural character.

I will keep bringing the same practical, open-minded approach to every decision—listening carefully, weighing the evidence, and putting the long-term interests of Charlestown residents first.

7. YES/NO: Do you think Ninigret Park should add lighting for recreational use during defined evening hours?

No response



Bonnita B. Van Slyke
Independent - Incumbent

1. What are your ideas for increasing affordable housing in Charlestown and how will you work to identify solutions?

A well-thought-out Affordable Housing Plan (AHP) is contained in our long-range Comprehensive Plan adopted in 2021. Described are creative partnerships, ordinance vehicles, and financing mechanisms that the town might pursue. For example, allowing mandatory inclusionary zoning as a mechanism to incorporate affordable housing within new developments of market-rate homes should be explored, and our Planning Commission is currently drafting such an ordinance. Converting manufactured homes or trailers; establishing a housing trust fund to support affordable housing production and rehabilitation; providing some degree of tax abatement in exchange for existing units meeting affordability requirements; allowing the transfer of development rights to provide

for housing density in appropriate locations; and placing another affordable housing bond, similar to the bond that helped the town provide forty affordable housing units since 2015, are possible strategies that could also be considered. Unfortunately, state legislation based on a one-size-fits-all approach will create a lot more market-rate housing in our community rather than affordability, will consume density that could be available for affordable housing, and will increase pollutant loading on our aquifers. I will continue to work to convince the state legislature to amend legislation that overrides environmental protections and to adopt the goals in the RI Executive Office of Housing's guide plan ("Housing 2030"), which matches affordable housing goals in RI communities to their current growth rates. I will work with my fellow Councilors to explore the local solutions outlined in our AHP.

2. How do you think the new consolidated Chariho regional elementary school being located in Charlestown will impact the town?

Should the voters determine that a consolidated elementary school should go forward, the construction of a school campus in Charlestown would benefit taxpayers in Charlestown, and those in the other two towns. In the end, it would cost less to build the two new buildings on the Charlestown site than it would for taxpayers to be required to pay for state-required upgrades to the three existing school buildings and maintain them into the future. In addition, Charlestown's elementary school students would be provided with two safe, modern school buildings that include innovative learning spaces on a separate campus, away from older students. Grade 5 students also would be brought back into the elementary school, as recommended by many educators and desired by parents. Because the construction would be staged, there would be less disruption to the student body, and the cost of providing another

location for students during construction would be avoided. These savings, and the fact that the cost of acquiring land would be avoided, would mean that more dollars could go to the construction of the buildings. Charlestown's offer is very generous and indicative of Charlestown's continued support of quality education. Nonetheless, Charlestown would lose the potential to use a very valuable property and the existing building for some other purpose, such as affordable housing. Traffic issues on Carolina Back Road, and particularly those that have arisen because pre-K students need to be transported to and from school by car, would need to be addressed.

3. What role should tourism, recreation, and facilities such as Ninigret Park play in the town's future?

"Tourism that sustains or enhances the geographical character of a place, its environment, culture, aesthetics, heritage and the well-being of its residents, will become in future years the only sustainable economy," to quote Myrna George, who was for many years president of the South County Tourism Council. Both residents and those who visit our town enjoy abundant outdoor recreation—going to the beach, fishing, hiking, renting a bike or kayak, stargazing, sightseeing, or learning about the history of the town. Charlestown's natural and cultural resources and rural character are what set Charlestown apart, sustain the health and well-being of our residents, and support tourism and our businesses. Ninigret Park is a cherished resource, but a \$39-million investment, or even a fraction of that, to make Ninigret Park the "economic engine of Charlestown" not only fails to demonstrate clear benefits to taxpayers or environmental compatibility, but this development is also unwanted, according to the professional Town-Wide Community Survey conducted in 2021.

4. What do you believe are the most important priorities when balancing

economic development, environmental protection and rural character?

Environmental protection needs to be our highest priority. The history and pattern of developed and undeveloped land and the mixture of land uses define the rural character of our community. We have no public water supply and no public sewage disposal, and using our land in ways that cannot be environmentally sustained would first affect our health and quality of life and then could force the RI Department of Environmental Management to require municipal infrastructure, costing taxpayers tens of millions of dollars. Tourism is a critical component of Charlestown's economy, and our fresh- and saltwater ponds, beaches, forested areas, river, and dark skies support our economy and high quality of life. Our rural character brings the seasonal residents who are important to our town's tax base and visitors that support our small businesses to Charlestown. Residents place environmental protection and the safety of their water supply as their highest priorities and prioritize their needs over those of tourists, as confirmed by the professional town-wide survey conducted in 2021. According to our long-range Comprehensive Plan adopted in 2021, "The vision for land use in Charlestown requires protection of natural resources and open space for both conservation and recreation; preservation of the town's heritage; protection of potable water and soils suitable for wastewater disposal; and provision of good-quality public services, including well-maintained transportation systems; and a safe and sustainable built environment, including housing."

5. What actions should Charlestown take regarding climate resilience and coastal preparedness?

Charlestown is vulnerable to impacts of more severe storms with high winds and heavy precipitation, coastal and riverine flooding, rising sea levels, and severe winter weather as a result of our

warming climate. In 2020, the town retained the Government Finance Officers Association (GFOA) to assess risks faced by the town, and based on the GFOA's report, developed a "Written Fund Balance Policy" that requires sufficient savings be reserved to enable the town to recover from emergencies and severe weather events without large increases in taxes being needed. It will be critical that the Town Council continually assess whether sufficient savings are dedicated for this purpose and not used for other purposes. In 2021, the town established a Climate Resiliency Commission charged with studying, analyzing, and developing strategies, policies, and plans for the mitigation of and adaptation to impacts from climate change that are within the capacity of local policies and actions, and with disseminating information to residents. For example, natural resources that are under public control or regulation will need to be properly managed, development in vulnerable areas prevented, public buildings hardened against natural hazards, and vulnerable roadways raised.

6. What differentiates you as a candidate and if elected, what will be your top priority during your term?

Having served on the Town Council for almost nine years, I bring a wealth of experience regarding the important issues facing our town and provide important balance to a Town Council where the current members belong to the same political group. As my top priority, I will continue to work to safeguard our natural and cultural resources so that our drinking water is clean, our salt- and freshwater ponds are healthy, our starlit skies are not hidden, our forests and wildlife flourish, and our culture and rural character are honored and respected.

7. YES/NO: Do you think Ninigret Park should add lighting for recreational use during defined evening hours?

No

★ ★ ★

Voice Your

★ ★ ★

CHOICE

★ ★ ★

Be Sure to Vote on Tuesday, November 3, 2026.



Charlestown General Election Candidates



CHARLESTOWN TOWN COUNCIL



Matthew Westover
Republican

1. What are your ideas for increasing affordable housing in Charlestown and how will you work to identify solutions?

-Affordable housing is a real problem in Charlestown. The majority of the new housing going up now comes with 7 figure price tags and are not designed or qualify as affordable housing. I'd like to see guidance set in place that requires new housing developments to designate a small reasonable portion of the project that meets the state's requirements for affordable housing. These guidance's should be controlled by the town and the planning board and not by one size fits all state mandates. Additionally, I'd like to see a few more smaller more affordable home constructed in town that are designated for young first-time home buyers.

2. How do you think the new consolidated Chariho regional elementary school being located in Charlestown will impact the town?

-I am a supporter of having 1 consolidated elementary school for Chariho. What I am not a supporter of is the location. The other two towns are getting their

land and buildings back to use as they please, while we are not. Referring to the previous question, this would be excellent land for affordable housing. I feel that there will also be added traffic as well as wear and tear on our roads. Some added traffic may help some local businesses but overall, I feel it would be a negative for our town. I would instead like to see the school be built near or on the current campus.

3. What role should tourism, recreation, and facilities such as Ninigret Park play in the town's future?

-These should play a huge role in our towns future. We have beautiful facilities, beaches, and trails for people to enjoy. People coming in from other areas to enjoy these wonderful things we have to offer help local businesses and our local economy. We need to dedicate special attention to ensuring these resources are around for decades to come for all to enjoy. Ninigret Park is one of our biggest resources for our town to utilize and I support having events and activities in the park while still being able to enjoy the natural beauty of the surrounding grounds.

4. What do you believe are the most important priorities when balancing economic development, environmental protection and rural character?

-Economic development and expansion is inevitable. I believe that when done responsibly, it doesn't have to be the scary reality that everyone views it as. Allowing our town to grow while maintaining the things that make our town feel like home is key. I believe that if you do what you can to maintain a rural small-town vibe, the rest can conform to fit that mark.

5. What actions should Charlestown take regarding climate resilience and coastal preparedness?

-Living in a coastal town, these topics are part of our everyday lives. I feel the town is making strong gains towards improving, especially with our coastline infrastructure. Charlestown beach road and the breachway are good examples of improvement projects that this town has taken on to improve our coastal preparedness and I'd like to see the town continuing to march down that road towards

long-term improvement. Living next to the ocean means large coastal projects will be part of our lives for years to come and I will do what I can to identify what areas need addresses and work towards a responsible plan of correction.

6. What differentiates you as a candidate and if elected, what will be your top priority during your term?

-I believe I am the only veteran running for town council. This gives me a unique perspective that no one else has, and I intend to use those skills I've learned for the betterment of the town. I also grew up in a small rural town in PA that has now been built up and lost its hometown feel. I intend to take some of the things I saw with my childhood home to try and help Charlestown not make those same mistakes.

7. YES/NO: Do you think Ninigret Park should add lighting for recreational use during defined evening hours? Only a Yes or No response will be printed.

Yes

Sasha Puchalski - no response



Charlestown General Election Candidates



CHARLESTOWN PLANNING COMMISSION

Nonpartisan



Katherine Gingras

1. What policies do you think need to be considered to deal with increasing extreme weather events?

We can always improve the ways in which we communicate the impending events and the plan in which we will be implementing. Publicize & Use the Social Media Channels as better ways to find out information. Keep them updated on the readiness by establishing better Preemptive Public Awareness Campaigns. The Campaigns should be both digital and in person.

2. How would you balance conservation with economic development?

We need to find common ground. To say that development is unnecessary and not happening would be false. Better knowledge of what is happening in our community would be the best option. Giving the community the information

in public platforms before decisions are made would make the most sense. But why and where need to be explained to the public better. Giving clear options and time to consider which ones they would choose.

3. What subdivision design features might you favor as compatible with Charlestown's existing neighborhoods?

Highly depends on the neighborhood's location and what those features would be. Certain areas, for example, would not benefit from pickleball courts and golf courses. We need to address the public access and parking situations. No matter what is proposed. We also need to publicly define what is the best areas for small commerce and encourage local business for community growth and support.

4. How will you balance individual property rights with protection of

neighboring properties and community interests?

To answer that question correctly I would need more information regarding the circumstances. Landownership disputes are easily resolved by clarifying property lines using accredited surveyors. Dispute resolution often depends deeply on what initiated the issue. When it involves the town using the land or people using their land for personal purposes that impacts the community; they need to follow the guidelines the town has established. Real resolution depends on all the options available and how they are presented. I firmly believe there is always more than one way to look at a problem. It is the Planning Commissions job to work together to make sure resolution in the best interest for everyone involved in the community.

5. Which planning decisions do

you think should remain with the full Planning Commission, and which can appropriately be handled administratively?

Strategic decisions are the pur view of the Planning Commission, implementation of that strategy and the tactics involved are the responsibility of the administrative staff

6. What planning considerations should guide Charlestown's regulation of large battery energy storage facilities and data centers?

Data centers would be inconsistent with our water supply and electrical grid.

7. Y/N: Do you support term limits for Planning Commission members?

Yes



Ruth L. Platner

1. What policies do you think need to be considered to deal with increasing extreme weather events?

In 2021 Charlestown's FEMA rating was the best in New England. Our community received high scores for actions that reduce flooding such as: preservation of natural open space; enforcing regulations for stormwater management, soil and erosion control; and prohibiting the creation of new lots in flood hazard areas.

Our town received a total of 2,394 points under FEMA's rating system. The highest points were for protected open space (932 points), higher regulatory standards (501 points), and the Charlestown Natural Hazard Mitigation Plan (200 points).

But since 2022, the town has stalled its program of open space acquisition and relaxed important subdivision standards that protect undeveloped land and manage stormwater. At the same time, the RI Legislature has passed laws that greatly increase the number of houses allowed per acre, made it much easier to get variances from regulation, and removed some of the community's ability to use environmental impact as a legal argument against over development.

The cumulative long-term effect of this

combination of relaxing local standards and state mandated increases in impacts will be a less resilient community.

Policies that reduce climate and extreme weather risks are already firmly anchored in Charlestown's Comprehensive Plan and in our Natural Hazard Mitigation Plan. We need to restore these policies into our regulations where they have been removed and then continue the process of implementing others from those plans. And most importantly we need to convince the RI Legislature to restore local control over planning and zoning.

2. How would you balance conservation with economic development?

Charlestown's economy depends on our natural and cultural resources. Economic activity in Charlestown is mainly based on tourism, which in turn is dependent on the health of our beaches, salt ponds, fresh water systems, inland open spaces, and historic villages.

A tourist can enjoy miles of unspoiled ocean beaches; hike in the 1,200-acre Carter Preserve and hear a Grasshopper Sparrow or see the flash of blue of an Indigo Bunting; canoe down our National Wild and Scenic Pawcatuck River; share in the Narragansett Tribe's August Meeting/Pow Wow; and experience the region's darkest skies at Frosty Drew Observatory — and that is just the short list.

The beauty of our natural environment is a treasure not just for tourists, but for those of us lucky enough to live here year-round. The actions we take to conserve these environmental assets protect our economy but also protect our own quality of life.

The threats to all of these are natural disasters, climate change, overuse, overdevelopment, and even state legislation. Some of Charlestown's natural resources are of national importance, others are important to the Rhode Island economy, all are important to South County, but increasingly they are threatened by actions of state government. What's lacking isn't a balance between conservation and our local economy — it's awareness at the RI State House that conserving our coastal community is essential to our state's long-term economic health.

3. What subdivision design features might you favor as compatible with Charlestown's existing neighborhoods?

Parcels large enough for major subdivision are mainly in northern Charlestown, where land is either rural in nature, or in or near one of the historic mill villages. Subdivision designs that prioritize the protection of natural resources, open space, agricultural lands, and sensitivity to historic resources will be the most compatible with existing neighborhoods, as well as sensitive to abutting forests, waterbodies, aquifers, and habitat areas.

Rhode Island law gives developers the right to submit applications to subdivide land and create new residential lots. Assuming no legislative overrides, the Charlestown Zoning Ordinance, along with the Charlestown Subdivision Regulations, defines how many lots can be created on a particular parcel. The current subdivision regulations use conservation design to allow that same number of lots, but configure them to reduce road lengths, protect more natural resources, and create meaningful open space.

Conservation design encourages protection of the quality of the town's groundwater; reduces impervious surfaces for better stormwater management; conserves open space for passive recreation and wildlife corridors; protects historical and archaeological resources; protects existing farms and forests; creates neighborhoods with direct visual and/or physical access to open space land; and keeps new lots away from abutting land uses by leaving some open space between the new development and existing houses or land.

These efforts are most successful in areas zoned for low density. They are somewhat harder to achieve where lots are zoned for higher density or where state laws are used to increase the number of allowed lots.

4. How will you balance individual property rights with protection of neighboring properties and community interests?

Landowners' rights are defined in state law and the town's subdivision and zoning regulations. Our town's regulations are based in science and are not arbitrary. They are written to be predictable, to try to keep conflicting activities physically separated, to protect natural resources including our dark skies, and to protect neighboring parcels.

However, our land-use regulations are under constant pressure from lobbyists at the state legislature who seek laws

that would overturn these regulations. Although most developers follow Charlestown's regulations, a handful of applicants push plans that far exceed what is prudent. With the increased density proposed in these plans, and the associated expensive infrastructure that would be required as a result, we could see extreme impacts on our spectacular natural resources, a diminished quality of life, and much higher tax rates.

The Planning Commission should work diligently to enforce the town's existing land-use regulations, but where state legislative actions result in negative impacts on our natural environment or other community interests, it will take a cooperative effort of the Planning Commission and the Town Council, along with the effort of the many other towns impacted by state override of local zoning, to protect community interests.

5. Which planning decisions do you think should remain with the full Planning Commission, and which can appropriately be handled administratively?

The legislature from 2023 through 2026 moved many applications and decisions that were previously before the seven-member Planning Commission in their public meetings to the Town Planner, who is the Administrative Officer, alone in a Town Hall office.

The law changes were designed for urban communities and are a bad fit for small towns like Charlestown, where there is only one Planner, no Town Engineer, large areas of still undeveloped land, no sewer or public water, and important natural resources.

Minor subdivisions were moved from the Planning Commission to the Town Planner and redefined from a threshold of 6 lots to 10. Most subdivisions in Charlestown have fewer than 10 lots, which means that most housing developments now do not have the benefit of public engagement and Planning Commission review. This removes not just public participation, but also the long-term community knowledge of the Planning Commission members. There can be a brief public review before Town Hall staff in one daytime meeting, but it doesn't compare to the previous process. Commercial developments of less than 7,500 square feet of floor area were moved from Commission review to Town Planner review. Most new commercial

development in Charlestown is likely to be below that 7,500-square-foot threshold and, like minor subdivisions, has been removed from the previous, very public process.

The likelihood of the RI Legislature reversing these changes is extremely low, but certainly no additional types or levels of review should be removed from the public process.

6. What planning considerations should guide Charlestown's regulation of large battery energy storage facilities and data centers?

On August 11, Charlestown added both battery energy storage facilities and data centers to the list of prohibited uses in the Zoning Ordinance.

Charlestown has very little land zoned industrial, and most of that is already fully used. Nearly all land in Charlestown, including land zoned industrial, either sits over our groundwater reservoirs and recharge areas or drains to the coastal ponds or the river system. Charlestown has no public water or sewer and depends on private wells for drinking water. Our aquifers are critical to the local drinking water supply and support unique ecological wetlands.

Data centers use massive amounts of water compared to other uses, and where they use evaporative cooling systems, the resulting wastewater can have concentrated minerals and possible contaminants. Data centers are a potential threat to wetlands and to the quality and quantity of our drinking water, and should remain a prohibited use in our town.

Battery Energy Storage Systems (BESS) are more complicated. At a large scale, they have an industrial appearance and are not appropriate for Charlestown. BESS are designed to store power during off-peak hours and then feed the electric grid during times of heavy use. We already have many potential energy storage devices connected to the grid in the form of electric cars and buses and backup devices for rooftop solar. Under the new ordinance these are meant to be allowed, but the ordinance will need to be revisited from time to time if new small-scale storage uses emerge.

7. Y/N: Do you support term limits for Planning Commission members?

No



Be Sure to Vote on Tuesday, November 3, 2026.



Charlestown General Election Candidates

CHARLESTOWN PLANNING COMMISSION

Nonpartisan



Laura Anne Rom

1. What policies do you think need to be considered to deal with increasing extreme weather events?

Underground utilities for new housing developments, which is already included in the Planning Commission standards. It would be great to have a Tree Commission and Warden to identify trees that are at risk especially along the busy main roads and preservation areas, however, that requires a professional at a cost. I do not believe Planning Commissions should have the authority to set specific subdivision requirements for potential weather events.

2. How would you balance conservation with economic development?

Charlestown has over 8,000 acres of preserves, conservation land, parks and ponds as well as miles of ocean. I worry about the long term maintenance of those areas. Charlestown does not have a Tree Warden, nor do they have a commission to maintain all this vast

land, they rely on a very small group of volunteers. I personally would love to see Charlestown never change it's rural character, but I also strongly believe that land owners have the right to develop their own property. Unfortunately, recent RI General Laws have allowed easier development with less Planning Commission control. Fortunately, commissions still maintain control over the standards of development.

3. What subdivision design features might you favor as compatible with Charlestown's existing neighborhoods?

The Subdivision and Land Development was adopted in January 2024, and last amended February 2025. This is a comprehensive document in conformance with state law, the Charlestown Comprehensive Plan and Town Zoning Ordinances, and will be reviewed and amended as needed. I like the standards for the Villages, I don't like the density policies that the state has implemented. I do not care for cluster developments, nor do I care for shared wells and septic

systems.

4. How will you balance individual property rights with protection of neighboring properties and community interests?

Charlestown is 100% dependent on wells and septic systems, with water supplied by natural aquifers. I worry about clear cutting the vast amounts of forest for large development, the available water supply, the storm water runoff, the rivers, but unfortunately, when the RIGL laws changed, the RI legislators did not consider rural areas dependent on wells and septic vs urban and suburban areas that have public utilities. They pass laws with one stroke of the brush.

5. Which planning decisions do you think should remain with the full Planning Commission, and which can appropriately be handled administratively?

Again, the RIGL have changed

laws with respect to Administrative vs Planning Commission responsibilities and has given more responsibility to the Town Planner and less to Planning Commissions. As long as the town maintains a good planner, I don't have an issue with the new state requirements.

6. What planning considerations should guide Charlestown's regulation of large battery energy storage facilities and data centers?

I support the Town Council's proposed ordinance to not allow energy storage or data centers in Charlestown. They can contribute greatly to tax relief but I do not think the impact to the environment, the impact on the infrastructure and the amount of water required to maintain a data center in such a rural area is worth the tax relief.

7. Y/N: Do you support term limits for Planning Commission members?

No



Frances M. Topping

1. What policies do you think need to be considered to deal with increasing extreme weather events?

As a policy, I would say, "The Planning Commission will take climate change into account in all actions and decisions made regarding residential and commercial developments, and incorporate resilience and sustainability into local development regulations." Some ways are Low Impact Development (LID) strategies, green infrastructure, stormwater design, and limiting development in floodplains and the percentage of impervious cover, which are in our regulations but may need enhancing.

As weather events become more frequent and severe, it is prudent to keep the Town's Hazard Mitigation Plan updated. The use of online "Storm Tools" provides a sea level rise indicator. There are many hazards to be monitored: coastal impacts, high winds, hurricanes, winter storm events, drought, temperature extremes, flooding, and potential pollution. Preservation of buffering dunes and salt marshes is important. Attention needs to be paid to emergency routes when reviewing development

applications, especially in high-flood or high-wind zones. Building codes also apply here. Roads need to be able to evacuate people, be resilient to flooding, and be ecologically sensitive, especially near the coast or other water bodies. Municipal buildings need to be considered to ensure they will be operable during major weather events. Public services residents rely on and which respond to major events need to ensure adequate capability. Warming and cooling centers should make sure they can meet the need. Such issues can be addressed in the Comprehensive Plan drafted by the Planning Commission with Town staff input and carried out through the Town Council and Town Administrator.

2. How would you balance conservation with economic development?

Conservation and economic development go hand in hand in Charlestown. Property taxes provide most of Charlestown's tax base. Charlestown is seen as an oasis between more developed areas. Our clean beaches, ponds, and river, our natural, undeveloped, mostly forested areas with many trails, and its historical components attract tourists and residents who support local businesses, as do I. Tourists enable many year-round businesses to succeed, compensating for a less well-attended off-season. Conserving these amenities is vital to the Town's economy. Services such as supermarkets are within easy reach in neighboring towns, and most are willing to go there to protect our more rural nature. Many businesses service the seasonal trade in construction, monitoring, and renting.

The Town could capitalize on being the most accessible dark sky area along the East Coast for sky watching with the availability of Frosty Drew Observatory and Science Center in Ninigret Park. Charlestown's position on the Atlantic flyway for migratory waterfowl, shorebirds, and songbirds, along with the National Wildlife Refuge here, could offer alternative attractions for tourists in the offseason if promoted. Conserving these attributes is an economic win for Charlestown. The Planning Commission does not solicit business, only evaluates applications. The Economic Improvement Commission is tasked with that. I welcome new small businesses and

economic incentives as long as they do not destroy the reason most people come here. The Planning Commission can facilitate conservation and small-scale businesses. Commercial Design Standards would ensure keeping Charlestown more traditional and unique.

3. What subdivision design features might you favor as compatible with Charlestown's existing neighborhoods?

While we cannot prohibit development, we can strive to make its impact less detrimental to the neighbors and the area and protect our natural resources. Subdivisions should not be overlarge or too dense for sustainability, as we generally rely on individual septic and wells. Science-based determinations should evaluate this. Ideally, they should integrate into the landscape, be buffered, and be considerate of each area's uniqueness, especially in the historic villages of e.g. Shannock, Carolina and Cross Mills. Ensuring Low Impact Development techniques, water conservation, and limiting impervious cover help protect neighbors' wells. Reducing nitrogen in the groundwater from runoff and septic is important. The subdivision regulations are designed to protect our resources and the neighborhoods. The State needs to acknowledge local control to best ensure the viability of our area and not override our regulations.

Conservation cluster subdivisions provide additional permanently protected undeveloped natural space typically owned by the cluster residents. It provides buffers to neighbors, can allow better siting, and allows more cleansing and recharge of groundwater and dilution of septic waste when houses are clustered on slightly smaller lots with larger undeveloped areas: better for water, wildlife, and people. Overall, the "yield" or number of lots stays the same.

4. How will you balance individual property rights with protection of neighboring properties and community interests?

This is difficult to accomplish; usually someone is understandably unhappy with the results of any development. Every subdivision and building changes

a neighborhood.. Property owners have a legal right to develop, provided State and subdivision and land development regulations, and Town zoning are met. Good design and buffering can help

Our subdivision and land development regulations are designed to minimize the impact. If Low Impact Development, good stormwater design, and best management practices are adhered to, the impact can be reduced. Good oversight is key. Experienced or committed Planning Commission members can make sure these are accomplished. Attention to detail is important. I oppose developments requiring more units than are sustainable, and that may impact neighboring wells and engender excess septic waste, endangering drinking water. Reducing nitrogen, especially in certain areas, is an issue we need to address. It is important, since too much nitrogen in drinking water is a health hazard, and to protect the ponds from unsightly, damaging "eutrophication" or algal buildup. Instituting regulations that affect many can be controversial and requires outreach to neighborhoods. I value public input. In my 12 years on the Planning Commission, I have endeavored to listen to the public and ensure regulations that help offset impacts are followed.

5. Which planning decisions do you think should remain with the full Planning Commission, and which can appropriately be handled administratively?

This is complex. The Planning Commission should still review and decide most development applications since they are elected to do this job. Some routine tasks can be handled solely administratively. Recent State laws have significantly changed the roles of the Planner and Planning Commission. If an applicant meets all requisite permitting regulations, the State now deems it able to be done administratively. Commercial property up to a 7,500 sq. footprint, which is large for Charlestown, can be administratively approved if no variances are needed. This could also involve other substantial developments. By bypassing the Planning Commission and reducing the stages of review, it may speed up the process, which the State

hopes will lead to more housing starts but can evade more scrutiny and cut out the public voice and, with it, important local knowledge. It reduces constructive idea input. I believe the new changes are detrimental to the town's welfare and burden the Planner. Even with a Technical Review Committee composed of key staff, the Planner may still require more specific technical knowledge, especially since there is no staff engineer. Such developments deserve full Commission evaluation. The Planning Commission has recently been given some zoning duties, deciding on variances if an application requests one. My preference is that variances revert to the Zoning Board, who have more experience with them.

The Planner and the Commission should and do work together, updating the Comprehensive Plan, the Hazard Mitigation Plan, various studies, and the subdivision and land development regulations.

6 What planning considerations should guide Charlestown's regulation of large battery energy storage facilities and data centers?

I agree with the recent prohibition of Data Centers and Commercial battery storage units. This gives the Town time to consider its options. Charlestown, which reon groundwater for its drinking water supply, cannot afford to service a water-hungry industrial use such as a data center. There is also no suitable and available land for such large buildings, as our industrial land is very limited. Natural resources and the character of Charlestown are limiting factors.

Battery storage also has some potential risks to the health and welfare of the community. Further study is possible in the future, but for now the prudent course was to prohibit them here.

Considerations of utmost importance are quality and quantity of available water, no removal of forest to accommodate them, and any situations such as fire or pollution entering the groundwater.

7. Do you support term limits for Planning Commission members? Y/N

No



Gordon S. Willcox

1. What policies do you think need to be considered to deal with increasing extreme weather events?

Planning, policy development and policy enhancement are critical to protect our extensive salt water ponds, barrier beaches and low-lying areas from intrusion of sea-level rise and water runoff during severe storms, heavy precipitation and storm surges. Appropriate zoning setbacks from wetlands, barrier beaches and other coastal areas are required to allow natural marshes to develop and manage surges during extreme weather events.

Planning Commission policy and decision-making must be closely aligned with Charlestown's Climate Resiliency Commission directives and FEMA-compliant Hazard Mitigation Plan

for high-risk areas to maintain eligibility for federal mitigation and disaster relief grants. Policies must empower the Climate Resiliency Commission to guide sustainability efforts, review vulnerability assessments and recommend policy changes to the Town Council.

In addition, storm water and inland flood planning and management are critical for protecting the integrity of our freshwater ponds and river system.

2. How would you balance conservation with economic development?

As a rural, costal community, we need to continue to enhance planning and policy that protects our natural resources - groundwater aquifers, forests, salt ponds - while permitting sensible, low impact economic development.

Compact zones for commercial businesses on primary roads, rather than "strip sprawl" throughout Charlestown, would help to mitigate the diminishment of the rural, farm and coastal character of our town. This could encourage the development of entrepreneurial businesses in a clustered and an appealing manner.

Zoning densities and commercial approvals must be developed with consideration of protecting our aquifers with respect to water quality and quantity. Deleterious water runoff from large building footprints and paving over large surfaces require careful consideration.

3. What subdivision design features might you favor as compatible with Charlestown's existing neighborhoods?

My wife and I are very pleased to be residents of one of Charlestown's first cluster developments. We have found that it is a subdivision type that provides increased protection for both the natural environment and abutting neighborhoods.

We should continue to refine cluster/conservation subdivision regulations.

Cluster zoning allows no more lots than a conventional subdivision, but increases the amount of open space and natural resource protection. The cluster process identifies and preserves the areas that are most important to protect from development.

A smaller developed area on suitable soils, surrounded by significant, mutually owned open space, maintains the goals of current traditional zoning requirements. The burden of septic discharge and water consumption on aquifers is effectively the same or less with cluster subdivisions than under existing standard zoning.

With any new subdivision, Charlestown must require strict storm water and site design standards to protect underlying ground water and runoff.

4. How will you balance individual property rights with protection of neighboring properties and community interests?

The Planning Commission is responsible for developing Charlestown's Comprehensive Plan. Decisions made for individual properties must be made in accordance with the Comprehensive Plan. The Comprehensive Plan establishes our town's long-term vision. The development and revision of the Comprehensive Plan is a transparent process made available to residents.

As an example, one of the Planning Commission's intents is to mitigate harm to neighboring properties to avoid situations such as clear cutting and paving on a bordering property that might threaten our aquifers or create or exacerbate storm water runoff.

As previously stated, cluster developments with significant land buffers and setbacks can result in protection of the privacy and property values of contiguous properties.

Community interests will be served by the Planning Commission strictly

adhering to the Comprehensive Plan that is inclusive of the public in its development. The protection of our natural resources - coastal areas, farms, rural areas, Ninigret Park, our aquifers for drinking water - along with the overall character of Charlestown, is the primary objective in managing residential and commercial growth and development.

5. Which planning decisions do you think should remain with the full Planning Commission, and which can appropriately be handled administratively?

Recent legislative changes that shift many planning and subdivision approval responsibilities away from our local elected Planning Commission to the Town Planner have resulted in less local input in the development decisions and a much heavier workload and responsibility to the Administrative Officer (Town Planner).

State law changes in the definition of a minor development may have little impact on Providence or other urban areas, but in Charlestown these changes are significant. Minor subdivisions can now consist of up to nine buildable lots before they trigger review before the Planning Commission. Previously, all subdivisions that resulted in new lots, both minor and major, were reviewed in a public process before the Commission.

Most land in our town that can be subdivided contains wetlands, or floodplains, or ledge, or stone walls, or some important feature known only to old-timers, regardless of how few lots are involved. Expedited administrative review may speed up the process, but it excludes the experience of the Planning Commission and the knowledge of the public, and that is not a good outcome for our town.

For rural towns, the legislature should consider moving all minor land development review back to the local board.

6. What planning considerations should guide Charlestown's regulation of large battery energy storage facilities and data centers?

I completely agree with the unanimous recommendation of the Charlestown Planning Commission in July 2026 to ban both data center projects and utility-scale battery storage facilities.

Charlestown relies on wells for our drinking water source. Data centers consume large amounts of water for cooling purposes and could significantly impact our aquifers and water table. In addition, these facilities usually require large impervious footprints with buildings and parking surfaces that would result in the clearing of large forested areas. Data centers are known to be noisy, run extensive external lighting from dusk to dawn, and consume large quantities of electricity that could destabilize local energy supply. Locating a data center in coastal zones could result in negative impact in these ecologically sensitive areas.

Battery energy storage facilities utilize lithium-ion batteries for storage, which raise significant concern for thermal runaway events. These events are highly difficult for local and rural fire departments to manage, including Charlestown's. The potential for catastrophic failure near residential areas or sensitive environmental zones is concerning.

It should be noted that this proposed recommendation by the Planning Commission does not apply to home energy management of battery storage from solar-generated energy or consumer products such as electric vehicles.

7. Y/N: Do you support term limits for Planning Commission members?

No

Cheryl A. Lill - no response

Colleen M. Galvin Yaroshenko - no response



Charlestown General Election Candidates

CHARLESTOWN SCHOOL COMMITTEE



Holly Eaves
Democrat - Incumbent

1. Civics is now required to graduate high school in RI. What do you think should be the balance between U.S. History, the country's founding principles, and hands-on civic engagement?

I believe there needs to be a balance between knowledge and experience. Students need a strong understanding of U.S. history and the founding principles of our country, including the Constitution, representative government, individual rights, and the responsibilities of citizenship. That historical foundation helps students understand how our government works and why it matters. At the same time, civics should not be limited to learning facts about government. Students should have opportunities to apply what they learn through hands-on civic engagement—such as student-led projects, participating in

local government, understanding how public decisions are made, and practicing respectful civil discourse. I would want students to learn to examine evidence, understand differing perspectives, think critically, and participate constructively even when they disagree. The goal should be to graduate students who are not only knowledgeable about our country's history and founding principles but are prepared and confident to participate in our democracy and their communities.

2. If pressed to reduce the budget bottom line, what specific cuts would you be willing to vote for and why?

There is relatively little discretionary spending in a school budget once contractual obligations and essential student services are considered. At this time, I would not identify a specific program or service for elimination without first understanding its impact. If reductions were necessary, I would look carefully for administrative efficiencies, shared services, and expenditures that could be deferred without harming students. I would weigh any proposed cuts thoughtfully, considering both their immediate and long-term consequences.

3. The district's fund balance has fallen to about 2% of the operating budget, well below the 5-7% auditors recommend for appropriate emergency response. What would you propose to do about it?

I believe maintaining an adequate fund balance is an important part of responsible financial management. Chariho's current policy establishes a fund balance range of 2-4% of general-fund expenditures and strives for 3%. The FY2026 budget intentionally used approximately \$2,480,000 of fund balance to reduce the amount charged to the member towns, leaving a budgeted reserve of about 2.2%.

I would favor revisiting the district's fund balance policy in light of current financial risks and the recommendations of our auditors and financial professionals. Before establishing a new target, I would want to understand the district's actual year-end financial position, obligations, and potential risks. If a higher reserve is warranted, I would support a deliberate, multi-year plan to rebuild it while balancing that goal against the needs of our students and taxpayers.

4. What qualities do you value in a superintendent and what criteria would you use to evaluate one? No names, please.

I value a superintendent who is student-centered, fiscally responsible, a good problem solver, respectful, and an effective leader. I would want a superintendent who regularly interacts with students, understands their experiences, and encourages them to take an active role in their own education. I would expect the superintendent to be a careful steward of taxpayer resources and to make thoughtful, sustainable financial decisions. As a problem solver and leader, the superintendent should listen to different perspectives, communicate clearly, build trust, and work collaboratively to address challenges. I would expect the superintendent to establish measurable goals in areas such as student achievement, attendance, educator retention, fiscal management, and facilities, with clear benchmarks and regular reporting to the School Committee and community. For example, with our elementary school facilities, I would expect the superintendent to establish clear milestones for planning and construction and demonstrate that the project is progressing on schedule and within the approved budget, while maintaining the educational priorities of the district. Similarly, if math achievement is identified as an area for improvement, I would expect a

specific, measurable goal with annual benchmarks and evidence-based strategies for improvement. I would evaluate not only whether these goals were achieved, but also whether the superintendent used data effectively, monitored progress, used resources wisely, communicated openly, and adjusted strategies when results indicated a need for improvement. Ultimately, I would look for a superintendent who demonstrates strong leadership while keeping the success and well-being of Chariho's students at the center of decision-making.

5. What are three things you would like the Chariho Regional School District to do differently and why?

Having served on the School Committee for only four months, I am still reacquainting myself with the district's current operations and would not want to identify changes simply for the sake of having three. I believe a School Committee member should understand an issue fully, examine the facts, consider multiple perspectives, and put the well-being of our students first, rather than allowing party ideology to drive decisions. One area where I would like to see continued improvement is communication and transparency. Major decisions—particularly those involving facilities, finances, and changes that affect students and families—should be accompanied by clear information about the facts, alternatives considered, costs, and rationale. I would like to see continued opportunities for meaningful two-way communication with families, educators, and the community. I would also like the district to continue strengthening its use of data to evaluate student outcomes and identify where additional support is needed. Chariho has many areas of academic strength, and we should learn from what is working while addressing areas where students or schools have room for

improvement. Finally, I would like to see continued long-term planning for both facilities and finances. The regional elementary school proposal is an important opportunity to address our facility needs while being responsible stewards of taxpayer resources. We should continue evaluating long-term costs, enrollment, educational needs, and the district's financial position. Most importantly, I would approach these areas with an open mind. My four months on the Committee have reinforced that good decisions require listening, asking questions, examining the facts, and considering multiple perspectives before deciding what, if anything, needs to change.

6. What differentiates you as a candidate and if elected, what will be your top priority during your term?

I bring a combination of engineering and business experience, 14 years teaching mathematics and computer science, prior and current School Committee service, and many years of community involvement. These experiences have taught me to listen, ask questions, examine the facts, and work collaboratively toward practical solutions rather than approach issues ideologically. If elected, my top priority will be ensuring that every Chariho student has the opportunity to succeed in a safe, supportive learning environment. I will focus on supporting excellent educators, addressing differences in student achievement, and making thoughtful, long-term decisions about our elementary facilities while being responsible stewards of taxpayer resources.

7. Yes/No: I fully support the proposed \$116 million bond referendum to replace the district's three aging elementary school on one elementary campus.

Yes



Craig F. Louzon
Democrat - Incumbent

1. Civics is now required to graduate high school in RI. What do you think should be the balance between U.S. History, the country's founding principles, and hands-on civic engagement?

I believe that all citizens should have a comprehensive understanding of our country, state, and local communities. The U.S. Constitution is one of the most remarkable documents in history. Understanding not only our rights but also our responsibilities as citizens—whether we are graduating from high school, entering college, or joining the workforce—is essential to fostering respect

for all individuals and upholding the spirit of our Constitution. I also believe that in order to understand how to fulfill our civic duties, we must teach history from all perspectives and acknowledge every aspect of our past. This is how we can truly uphold our country's founding principles. We cannot fully understand what it means to be a proud U.S. citizen without recognizing both the successes and failures that have shaped our nation. We should always strive to encourage our students to learn more, think critically, and understand the lessons of history so that future generations can avoid repeating the mistakes of the past.

2. If pressed to reduce the budget bottom line, what specific cuts would you be willing to vote for and why?

As a member of the school committee, my last choice for a budget cut would be staffing in our schools. Our primary objective is to provide a quality education for all of our students, and our staff are essential to achieving that goal. That being said, making budget cuts is never easy. However, as we know, particularly given our current economic climate, there may be times when difficult decisions and reductions are necessary. Historically, Chariho's budgets have often increased at a rate below the Consumer Price Index (CPI) and inflation. If faced with the need to make cuts, I would make every effort to listen to our community, including our students, as well as Chariho's administrators, teachers, and staff. By considering a wide range of perspectives and carefully evaluating our priorities, we can make the most informed and responsible decisions possible while keeping the education and well-being of our students at the center of

every decision.

3. The district's fund balance has fallen to about 2% of the operating budget, well below the 5-7% auditors recommend for appropriate emergency response. What would you propose to do about it?

This specific subject is actually one that I have personally requested as a future agenda item for a school committee meeting because I feel that we should be at least within a safe range of 4-6%. However, I understand that it would take years to get to this point. We simply don't have enough money in the fund balance for even one catastrophic event. Additionally, if this November's bond fails, we are going to need all types of money to continue to fix the current three elementary schools that we have to keep them operational.

4. What qualities do you value in a superintendent and what criteria would you use to evaluate one? No names, please.

The qualities I value most in a superintendent are honesty, openness, vision, strong listening skills, and a commitment to putting students first. A successful superintendent should also be willing to communicate openly and effectively with all members of our district and work collaboratively with students, families, educators, staff, and the community. When evaluating a superintendent, there are federal and state guidelines that provide a framework for conducting the process fairly and effectively. As a School Committee, however, our evaluation of the superintendent should not be limited

to a single annual review. It should be an ongoing, year-round process that includes regular communication, observation, and feedback. The evaluation should be based on clear and meaningful criteria that reflect the qualities and leadership skills we expect from a superintendent while also considering the unique needs of our community. Ultimately, the goal should be to ensure that our superintendent is providing strong leadership, maintaining open communication, and keeping the success and well-being of our students at the center of every decision.

5. What are three things you would like to see the Chariho Regional School District do differently and why?

First, I would love to see the Chariho Regional School District and our community come together to pass a building bond that finally addresses the infrastructure needs of our elementary schools and provides the facilities our youngest learners deserve. Second, I would like to see Chariho reach a place where difficult conversations can take place without discomfort, tension, or division. We are fortunate to have such a diverse and passionate community, and I believe disagreements can strengthen our work as a School Committee when they are approached with respect, kindness, and a willingness to listen. I believe there is always room for improvement in how we communicate with one another, and that includes myself. Lastly, I would like to see Chariho continue working toward providing our community with clear, concise, and accessible information while creating more opportunities for meaningful engagement. At times, misinformation can spread through-

out our district, and I would like to see Chariho take a more proactive approach by creating additional opportunities for community members to ask questions, receive accurate information, and stay informed. Building trust through open and consistent communication will help strengthen our entire community.

6. What differentiates you as a candidate and if elected, what will be your top priority during your term?

I believe my experience as a multi-term School Committee member, a parent of four wonderful Chariho graduates, and a member of various committees and subcommittees has given me a deep understanding of the needs of our district. Over the past 15 years, I have been actively involved in multiple building bond initiatives and have remained a present and engaged member of the process as Chariho has grown and evolved. One way or another, this will be the last time I run for the Chariho School Committee. If elected, my goal is to help ensure that our district remains strong, safe, and focused on the success of every student. My top priorities will be improving our facilities and ensuring that all of our students have access to the education, resources, and support they need to succeed. I am proud of the experience and perspective I bring to this role, and I am committed to using both to help move Chariho forward.

7. Yes/No: I fully support the proposed \$116 million bond referendum to replace the district's three aging elementary schools on one elementary campus?

Yes



Linda Lyall
Democrat - Incumbent

1. Civics is now required to graduate high school in RI. What do you think should be the balance between U.S. History, the country's founding principles, and hands-on civic engagement?

I believe students need all three. A strong civics education should begin with a solid understanding of U.S. history and the founding principles of our country, including the Constitution, separation of powers, individual rights, and the responsibilities of citizenship. Students cannot fully understand our government or participate meaningfully in civic life without understanding how we got here. But civics cannot stop with a textbook. Students should also have opportunities

for hands-on civic engagement—understanding how local government works, attending or participating in public meetings, learning how budgets are developed, evaluating sources of information, and respectfully discussing issues with which they may disagree. The goal should be to graduate students who understand both the rights they have and the responsibilities they carry as citizens, and who are prepared to participate thoughtfully in their communities.

2. If pressed to reduce the budget bottom line, what specific cuts would you be willing to vote for and why?

At the beginning of the budget process, I try not to begin with an arbitrary percentage reduction or identify cuts simply because they are politically convenient. I would first anticipate the administration will provide a clear picture of every proposed reduction and its impact on students, classrooms, staffing, and educational outcomes as they have done in every budget process. If reductions were necessary, I would prioritize eliminating or reducing non-instructional administrative costs, duplicative services, unnecessary contracts, discretionary spending, and expenditures that do not directly support student learning. I would also look carefully at opportunities for shared services, efficiencies, technology, purchasing, and scheduling. I would be very reluctant to make cuts that directly reduce classroom instruction, essential student services, special education support, or programs that are producing measurable results. Fiscal responsibility means recognizing that every taxpayer dollar matters while also recognizing that cutting something simply to reduce a number is not

necessarily responsible stewardship.

3. The district's fund balance has fallen to about 2% of the operating budget, well below the 5-7% auditors recommend for appropriate emergency response. What would you propose to do about it?

I believe rebuilding the fund balance should be an important priority, and it should be done through a deliberate, multi-year plan rather than trying to correct the problem with one dramatic budget increase. The School Committee should establish a reasonable fund-balance target based on auditor and financial-advisor recommendations and develop a plan to move toward that target while still meeting the district's educational obligations. I would also want greater transparency about why the fund balance declined, what assumptions are being made about future expenses and revenues, and what financial risks the district faces. A healthy reserve protects students and taxpayers. It gives the district the ability to respond to unexpected costs without immediately cutting programs or going back to taxpayers for additional money. Maintaining an appropriate reserve is part of responsible long-term financial management.

4. What qualities do you value in a superintendent and what criteria would you use to evaluate one? No names, please.

I value a superintendent who is student-centered, collaborative, accountable, financially responsible, transparent, and willing to listen. A superintendent needs to be an effective educational leader, but also a strong manager of a complex organization. I

would look for someone who can develop and execute a clear strategic plan, support teachers and administrators, communicate effectively with families and the community, manage the budget responsibly, and make decisions based on evidence rather than ideology. Evaluation should be based on clearly established goals and measurable outcomes. I would look at student achievement and growth, graduation rates, staff retention and morale, progress on strategic-plan goals, fiscal management, compliance with state requirements, communication with the School Committee and community, and the overall effectiveness of district operations. Most importantly, I would expect the superintendent to be accountable for results while also giving the administration the professional authority to manage the day-to-day operation of the district.

5. What are three things you would like to see the Chariho Regional School District do differently and why?

First, improve long-term financial planning. The district needs a sustainable approach to budgeting, capital planning, and maintaining an appropriate fund balance. We should avoid simply addressing financial challenges one budget cycle at a time. Second, strengthen communication and transparency. Families, staff, and taxpayers should be able to understand why major decisions are being made, what alternatives were considered, and how those decisions affect students and taxpayers. Better communication builds trust, even when people disagree with the outcome. Third, establish clearer measures of success. The district has many initiatives underway, but the School Committee and community should be able to see

whether those initiatives are actually improving student outcomes. We should identify measurable goals, monitor progress, and be willing to change course when something is not working.

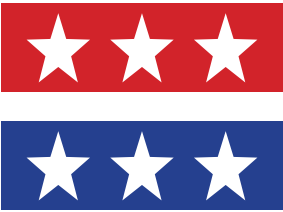
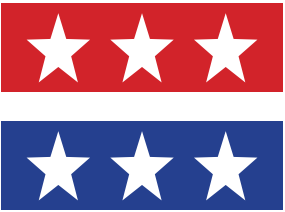
6. What differentiates you as a candidate and if elected, what will be your top priority during your term?

What differentiates me is that I bring a practical, collaborative, and results-oriented approach to School Committee service. I believe strongly in public education, but I also believe that good intentions are not enough. We need to look at the evidence, listen to the people doing the work, understand the financial implications, and then make responsible decisions. I am willing to listen to perspectives with which I may disagree and to have difficult conversations respectfully. I also understand that a School Committee member's responsibility is to make decisions in the best interest of the entire Chariho community—not simply one neighborhood, one group, or one point of view. My top priority would be ensuring that Chariho provides an excellent education while putting the district on a sustainable financial and operational path. That means maintaining academic progress, supporting students and educators, addressing aging facilities responsibly, rebuilding financial reserves, and making sure taxpayers can trust how their money is being spent.

7. Yes/No: I fully support the proposed \$116 million bond referendum to replace the district's three aging elementary schools on one elementary campus?

Yes

Kim M. Coulter - no response
Nichola Testa - no response



Richmond General Election Candidates
RICHMOND TOWN COUNCIL



Douglas Deslauriers
Democrat

1. What are the most important priorities when balancing economic development, environmental protection and rural character?

Protecting the environment must come first, as it is the base ingredient of rural character. Ensuring the long-term stability of the ecosystem will prevent costly remediation efforts later on. The short-term economic gains from unrestricted development of wild lands is not sustainable and cannot easily be undone. With that said, a project that might disrupt any amount of the environment should not be denied without consideration. The benefits to all residents should be weighed against potential downsides to the environment. Rural character means more than

just open fields and vast forests. When considering whether a project will fit the rural character, it is essential to prioritize cohesiveness. The I-95 corridor is already built up, and it makes the most sense for denser developments to be in that area. Whereas further from the main roads, small duplexes and lightly concentrated housing developments help contain sprawl and preserve forests, maintaining rural character.

2. What approach would you take to evaluate new commercial development proposals?

I would first review the relevant documents and planning and/or zoning board public meeting minutes related to this development. There are experts there who would have taken a first look at these proposals and will have insights beyond what I alone as an individual could see. For what I would consider, every proposal would first be evaluated to see what benefits the development would bring to residents. Examples of such benefits include new services, job opportunities, recreation, and of course tax revenue. The developer won't be taken at face value for those values either, so an independent consideration of the realistic usefulness would be performed. Next the impact on the local area will be evaluated. For example, what effects would the development have on the environment, surrounding houses and businesses, or rural character? Negative impacts will be weighed against the potential benefits that the business could bring. Finally, I would look at the impact to the town as a whole, to determine whether the development makes sense for Richmond.

3. How do you think the recent changes in staffing and town hall hours

have improved the efficiency and effectiveness of town government? What if any additional changes would you suggest?

The recent changes in staffing and town hall hours have increased the effectiveness of the town government. Being open for one less day a week has saved the town money. While residents are unable to do their business at town hall on Friday, the increased hours on Tuesday have allowed some people who work a 9-5 job, to have some extra time to stop by after work. I have not yet heard from constituents any negative sentiment about the town hall hours. Further cuts to staffing and town hall hours likely only see diminishing returns as far as cost, and would reduce the availability for residents. As of right now, I don't see any clear opportunities to rework the town hall hours, but I would be open to minor suggestions, from residents and especially from the staff who have to work these hours.

4. What opportunities do you see for reducing long-term municipal operating costs?

I see opportunities to invest now to reduce operating costs later, such as using excess fund balance to pay for roadwork projects every year. Holding off infrastructure projects until many roads are unusable, and then asking residents for a multimillion dollar bond in the future is not fiscally responsible policy. Paying for the repaving of roads using funds available now will save money over time. Specifically avoiding having to pay interest fees on borrowed bond money. Another way to reduce operating costs would be to train an existing staff member to manage the energy usage of town facilities. Ensuring someone is responsible for turning off lights, programming

the HVAC systems with the daily schedule of use, and recommending energy saving upgrades to the buildings reduces electricity and heating expenditures, for the cost of a small stipend. While this would help the town, it would be more effective if coupled with a joint effort to do the same things at Chariho's much more energy intensive school buildings. While this may not necessarily reduce operating costs, working with the State to send existing financial aid to Chariho directly would help clean up our finances. The aid they provide to the town budget for schooling must go to Chariho, so sending it directly wouldn't change Chariho's budget, but would allow the town to keep a smaller fund balance. Our revenues and expenses would more accurately reflect what the town is actually able to raise and spend.

5. How do you envision Richmond partnering with neighboring communities to share municipal facilities and services?

Chariho is of course the largest existing example of shared facilities and services, and should continue to be. Richmond should also continue to share services with Hopkinton, such as our recreation centers and transfer station, provided a fair share is paid for usage. The library system in Rhode Island is shared and open to residents already. I don't really see too many realistic opportunities available for the sharing of more facilities and services. I would certainly be open to reciprocal sharing with neighboring communities, if the proposals were made. There may be some possibilities of buying or contracting services as a group of towns, which may be cheaper in some circumstances. However, due to the added accounting burden and coordination efforts it may not be worth it.

6. What differentiates you as a candidate and if elected, what will be your top priority during your term?

I believe that I can bring new eyes to the town council. Since I was fortunate enough to buy my house in Richmond seven years ago, I only know the recent history here, but that means I won't have much in the way of preconceived notions about how things should be. I'm willing to question why things are done a certain way, and look for alternatives. With that said, I also value the perspectives of those who have more experience and time spent with the town and will use them to inform my own views. It is certainly important to know how things got to where they are. As with the parable of Chesterton's Fence, you should not reform a thing until you know why it was put there in the first place. My top priority will be to increase the affordability of housing in Richmond. This will be a long-term project for which I hope to make near-term changes that will pay off in the future. Notably, I would like to encourage, and in fact sometimes require, the development of smaller houses. Smaller houses will be more affordable on the market, and will allow residents to age in place, new families to get a start here, and Chariho graduates have the option to put down roots. Where they make sense, I would also be happy to approve development proposals which include multifamily housing that fits the character of the town.

7. Yes/No: Will you support housing developments that do not threaten our water resources, include required affordable housing units and hold developers responsible long term?

Yes



Paul Erdos
Republican

1. What are the most important priorities when balancing economic development, environmental protection and rural character?

The most important priority is the person/people that already call Richmond home and the impact that decisions will have on their already established lives and living situations. This primary consideration frames the economic, environmental, and rural character components as being equally weighted as secondary. 2. What approach would you take to evaluate new commercial development proposals? It's not sure if this is a question about developing commercial businesses or big outside companies coming in to develop housing plans. My approach to new Commercial Development proposals would be whether they are helpful and necessary to meet provable local needs or create local opportunities to the constituents of our existing community. As a builder my preference is that local builders, with local recognition, and

local accountability would be the ones building our town.

3. How do you think the recent changes in staffing and town hall hours have improved the efficiency and effectiveness of town government? What if any additional changes would you suggest?

The recent changes to town hall hours haven't had enough time to prove whether efficiency or effectiveness has improved. I'm not opposed to creative solutions such as a 4 day schedule but it certainly must be weighted against the expectation of access to public services. I would wait until I am elected to better understand what changes or improvements might be helpful. 4. What opportunities do you see for reducing long-term municipal operating costs? I am a firm believer in pro-active instead of reactive operations. In business I have learned that good tools and efficient systems are a tremendous long

term net-positive. I see one of the biggest vulnerabilities that governing bodies tend towards is to take on too much or try to be the solution for every difficulty or demand, and naturally, services cost money. As a Republican I am committed to lean government and empowering individuals to be resilient and resourceful, while at the same time removing redundant and unnecessary procedures that stifle the entrepreneurial endeavors.

5. How do you envision Richmond partnering with neighboring communities to share municipal facilities and services?

Mutual aide agreements should exist between neighboring communities but I am not a fan of centralizing in a formal or permanent way. Due to the inherent differences that each town has, it would be unnecessarily difficult, if not impossible, to fairly and equally distribute resources.

6. What differentiates you as a candidate and if elected, what will be your top priority during your term?

No

What differentiates me as a candidate is my personality and passion. I am not one to sit back and think that it's somebody else's job; at the same time I don't jump into a solution without properly researching and understanding as much as I can before acting. I have often said "there are never problems, only opportunities" and I endeavor to practice that. My top priority will be to excite the passions of community and patriotism within our citizens so they will expect and participate in the continued formation of our town. This will happen by reducing the costs to live and do business in Richmond, and by establishing good policy that encourages healthy growth and opportunity.

7. Yes/No: Will you support housing developments that do not threaten our water resources, include required affordable housing units and hold developers responsible long term?



Daniel E. Madnick
Democrat

1. What are the most important priorities when balancing economic development, environmental protection and rural character?

For Richmond, the top priority is preserving the rural character of the community that residents value. The second priority is supporting sustainable economic development while preventing urban sprawl. These priorities are not mutually exclusive and can be achieved within a framework of responsible environmental protection. For example, the Aquifer Protection Overlay District that protects our sole source aquifer was recently amended to allow business growth within the aquifer area subject to specific criteria. This demonstrates that we can be flexible and support new economic opportunities while protecting an important environmental resource. Moving forward, the best approach is to focus higher-density development in specific areas of the community that are already identified as growth areas in Richmond's Comprehensive Community Plan (CCP). At the same time, the town must maintain zoning regulations that limit higher density development outside of those areas. In Richmond the designated growth area for higher density development is located primarily around the 95/138 interchange, with smaller designated growth areas in Shannock and

Alton. The Town Council I serve on prioritized working with the stakeholders in Chariho Plaza and Richmond Commons to achieve a start to the priorities mentioned above. It is important that elected officials, staff, our volunteer boards and commissions, residents, and business stakeholders all work collaboratively to protect what makes Richmond a great place to live and develop in a mutually beneficial manner.

2. What approach would you take to evaluate new commercial development proposals?

Richmond has an active and engaged Planning Board with oversight of development. It evaluates proposals for consistency with Richmond's Comprehensive Community Plan. The Economic Development Commission (EDC) does not have development oversight, but has been working to identify the business needs of the community and improve access for residents interested in starting a small business. The Town Council becomes involved when a proposal requires changes to town ordinances, with recommendations from the Planning Board and input from the EDC guiding Council consideration. The best approach is a proactive, collaborative, and focused municipal government that balances community priorities with economic realities. The recent proposal to modify the Richmond Commons Planned Unit Development - Village Center (PUD-VC) zoning ordinance is a great example. The 246-acre property's zoning amendment resulted from an 18-month collaboration involving the property owner, myself, Councilor Palmisciano, town staff, EDC Chair Parker, and Planning Board Chair Damics. We worked with the property owner to address needs including low-impact commercial development, indoor and outdoor recreation, and opportunities for mixed-use development, small businesses, and housing. The Council then adopted a revised ordinance providing the property owner flexibility to respond to changing market conditions while maintaining the property's mixed-use vision and addressing the community's recreational needs. This collaborative approach represents a positive change in how Richmond can address development. I will continue taking a proactive approach that encourages responsible development, protects Richmond's rural character, and ensures that new proposals provide meaningful

benefits to our community.

3. How do you think the recent changes in staffing and town hall hours have improved the efficiency and effectiveness of town government? What if any additional changes would you suggest?

One of my goals upon joining the Council was to identify opportunities to improve town operations, reduce costs to taxpayers, and improve the level of service residents receive. As a supervisor at Electric Boat, I rely on the people closest to the work to identify opportunities for improvement, and I applied that same approach towards improving efficiency for the town. I worked with Councilor Dinsmore, who has municipal experience in Westerly, and Administrator to take a critical look at our operations, gather staff input, and develop recommendations for the Council. This led to a reorganization of the Finance Department, a reduction in full-time positions, and changes to several Town services. The Transfer Station was closed on Tuesdays, while Wednesday hours were extended after receiving feedback from residents that a late evening would be beneficial. Town Hall staff also transitioned to a four-day workweek, while maintaining and improving public access by opening earlier in the morning and remaining open later on Tuesday evenings. So far, the response to the new Town Hall hours has been positive. The Town is also evaluating a reorganization of the DPW and potential changes to the Personnel Ordinance. There may also be an opportunity to re-organize the recreation, senior activities, and human services positions, depending on the needs of the community. This is an ongoing effort that will continue to be a top priority for me as a council member and steward of taxpayer resources.

4. What opportunities do you see for reducing long-term municipal operating costs?

Personnel and benefits make up a substantial portion of the Town's recurring expenses. As a Councilor, I will continue working with the Town Administrator to evaluate staffing levels, determine how work is organized and scheduled, and look for opportunities to improve efficiency, thereby limiting operating expense increases. We need to consider how investing taxpayer dollars now can

reduce costs over the long term. For example, investing in infrastructure and equipment before they become major problems can save taxpayers significantly more money in the future, such as sealing of roads instead of waiting until they require a full reclamation. Investing in road maintenance and sealing can extend the life of our roads and delay much more expensive reclamation projects. That's why I supported allocating \$550,000 for roads in FY2025/26 and another \$300,000 in FY2026/27. Over the last two years, the Council has demonstrated that taking a critical eye to each budget line item can result in fiscal discipline and maintaining services that our residents expect. Taxes were held flat in FY2025/26, and in FY2026/27 the council reduced municipal spending while still providing merit increases and additional funding for roads. To maintain the same level of service that the community expects, retain staff, and fund capital improvements, the council needs to consider what we are spending, why we are spending it, and if there is a better way to provide the same service.

5. How do you envision Richmond partnering with neighboring communities to share municipal facilities and services?

Partnering with neighboring communities and sharing services is especially important for small towns like Richmond. The town should be willing to look at opportunities where working together can provide better services or reduce costs for taxpayers in the communities we serve. Currently, Richmond shares the Transfer Station with Hopkinton, and our DPW regularly exchanges equipment and resources with surrounding communities. More recently, the Councils of Richmond, Charlestown, and Hopkinton held a Tri-Town meeting where we asked the Town Administrators to identify opportunities for cost sharing. Regarding the Transfer Station, during a joint meeting with the Hopkinton council, we reached an agreement for an increased contribution from Hopkinton toward operating costs, with the agreement to be reviewed annually. I would like to see us continue looking for opportunities to share equipment, facilities, personnel, and services where it makes operational and financial sense. At the same time, agreements need to be clear about costs, division of responsibilities, and expectations. An open-minded and collaborative

approach will allow Richmond and our neighboring communities to find ways to reduce costs, improve efficiency, and maintain the services our residents expect

6. What differentiates you as a candidate and if elected, what will be your top priority during your term?

What differentiates me is the combination of my engineering background, planning board and land use experience, and commitment to bringing people together to solve problems. I am trained to solve problems and look at issues objectively, understand the facts, listen to different perspectives, identify constraints, and develop practical solutions. I try to bring that same approach to the Town Council. We need to understand the facts, consider different viewpoints, weigh the benefits and drawbacks of each decision, and make a decision that is in the community's best interest. Prior to being elected to the Town Council, my five years on the Planning Board provided me with a strong understanding of land use, development, and the importance of our Comprehensive Community Plan, along with knowledge of the community's needs. My experience has taught me that planning for Richmond's future requires balancing growth and economic opportunity with the rural character and quality of life that residents value. I am proud of what the current Council has accomplished and humbled by the opportunity to improve our town over the last two years. My top priority is to plan thoughtfully for Richmond's future while addressing the needs of our community today. That means implementing the vision of our Comprehensive Community Plan, investing pragmatically in infrastructure and recreation, and finding opportunities to address issues Richmond is currently experiencing. Ultimately, Richmond should be a community that doesn't simply react to problems, but anticipates them, is proactive, and brings people together to develop practical solutions.

7. Yes/No: Will you support housing developments that do not threaten our water resources, include required affordable housing units and hold developers responsible long term?

Yes



Be Sure to Vote on Tuesday, November 3, 2026.



Richmond General Election Candidates

RICHMOND TOWN COUNCIL



Norbert L. Morin
Republican

1. What are the most important priorities when balancing economic development, environmental protection and rural character?

We want to protect the environment to live here without fearing water, ground, or air pollution. As a balance, we do not want to make rules that are unnecessary and prevent development or make it so expensive that the middle-class person or company cannot build a house or open their business here.

We want to protect our rural character. We can do that by banning solar “farms” from any location except industrial

or commercial zoned areas. We can encourage, though not force, people to leave trees on their properties. Trees keep the water table high and prevent loss of water in the aquifer. Trees cool the ground under them and provide environment for rabbits, squirrels and other animals to live.

We need economic development if we are to offset rising taxes on residents. We could accomplish this by focusing on inviting companies looking for regional warehouses to obtain property in the Richmond commercial and industrial areas. That could bring income to the town without adding additional expenses in police department size or increased number of children in school.

2. What approach would you take to evaluate new commercial development proposals?

What impact would it have on our tax structure - is it an improvement to our community and what was the impact if any to our surrounding environment.

As stated earlier, we should actively seek companies who might want a regional distribution center which would bring income to the town only minimally increasing expense to the town. Our location near Route 95 makes us ideal for this type of company. We would need to ensure that our town planning department or commission did not make the process of opening so expensive or arduous that they choose another town.

3. How do you think the recent changes in staffing and town hall hours have improved the efficiency and effectiveness of town government? What if any additional changes would

you suggest?

The town hall has saved some money with the reduction in hours, but it appears as if the Town Hall is closed too frequently causing inconveniences to our residents. I believe they have 15 holidays, in addition to only being open 4 days a week. We might also reduce municipal operating costs by examining places where government is duplicating services or over staffing.

4. What opportunities do you see for reducing long-term municipal operating costs?

It is my understanding that the transfer station under the jurisdiction of the department of public works is not the most efficiently run department. My suggestion would be to have an outside firm evaluate current practices and make appropriate recommendations. We might also evaluate whether it would provide savings to have an outside firm run the transfer station. We would not need to pay town employees to run the transfer station, which include their pay, health benefits, vacation & sick time, and retirement costs.

The biggest problem we have is the cost of the Chariho School System. The cost to Richmond went from \$22 million for the year, to \$23 million IN ONE YEAR! We cannot afford that. The town took \$1million dollars from our Fund Balance (the town’s savings account) to cover the extra million in expenses. We will be out of a savings account if that continues. I do not have an answer to the school problem, but we have a problem that is not sustainable.

Local non-profits possess professional staff far better equipped to meet

human services I propose eliminating the Municipal Court and the Department of Human Services.

The Public Works transfer station is a frequent source of taxpayer frustration regarding its lack of efficiency and recent \$73,000 operating deficit. I will request an independent, outside firm to audit and evaluate our transfer station operations. Taxpayers deserve lean, modernized, and professional town services, not an ever expanding bureaucracy

5. How do you envision Richmond partnering with neighboring communities to share municipal facilities and services?

We should adopt best practices from all 3 – one size however does not fit all. We should be questioning how other communities have lowered cost to see if that practice is feasible for Richmond.

We could use our collective buying power. Richmond, Hopkinton, and Charlestown already share a school district, and we could expand that tri-town mindset to municipal operations. As a fiscal conservative, I will propose a regional purchasing collective for town vehicles, heavy DPW equipment, and bulk supplies. By pooling our orders, all three towns can negotiate steep volume discounts that aren’t available to us individually. While a ‘one-size-fits-all’ approach doesn’t work for everything, we absolutely should be analyzing and adopting the best cost-saving practices of our neighbors to keep our own tax rate low.”

6. What differentiates you as a candidate and if elected, what will be your top priority during your term?

As Director of Purchasing my experience has been invaluable and results-oriented opportunity to solve problems. I will ask the town council to begin a process of evaluating cost-benefit evaluations in many areas of town government. As a senior citizen I am looking at what benefits the town could be developing to lower property taxes on those 65 and older. Seniors should not be contributing 80% of their property taxes to education. We are currently contributing 20% to the infrastructure which is being neglected because of lack of funds.

“What differentiates me is 40 years of corporate procurement expertise, including 26 years as a purchasing director at Hasbro approach to fiscal management that Richmond Town Hall desperately needs.

If elected, my top priority is restructuring our town budget to deliver meaningful property tax relief for seniors 65 and older. Right now, our seniors carry an unfair burden—being on limited incomes while funding roughly 80% of our local education costs through property taxes while our roads, bridges, and infrastructure are severely neglected from a lack of funds. As a Certified Purchasing Manager (C.P.M.), I am knowledgeable in corporate cost-cutting strategies. I will use my negotiation background to audit municipal waste, reinvest in our crumbling town infrastructure, and protect our seniors from being priced out of their homes.”

7. Yes/No: Will you support housing developments that do not threaten our water resources, include required affordable housing units and hold developers responsible long term?

No



Jim Palmisciano
Democrat

1. What are the most important priorities when balancing economic development, environmental protection and rural character?

Economic development is critical to establish a commercial tax base to help

offset the cost of running the town so that the burden does not rest entirely upon the residents. It’s not a quick fix, and it has to be done correctly. We’re fortunate to have a very clear guiding document in our comprehensive community plan which identifies the areas determined as development zones. We also have large amounts of protected open space to not only ensure we maintain the rural character of our community. Using the comprehensive community plan as a guiding document, along with the planning board, we’ll ensure that we will have smart development in zoned commercial areas and maintain the rural character of our community for years to come.

2. What approach would you take to evaluate new commercial development proposals?

Allow the planning board process to take place and support them in doing their job, listen to their inputs and review their recommendations, and make legislative decisions based on this input balanced with the needs of the community. As a council we have also demonstrated efforts to attract businesses to Richmond, working with the planning board and prospective developers to ensure zoning is appropriate to protect our town and its resources, while enabling flexibility for a vibrant and varied business community.

3. How do you think the recent changes in staffing and town hall hours have improved the efficiency and effectiveness of town government? What if any additional changes would you suggest?

Hiring Erin Liese as the town administrator was a great decision for our town. She comes with vast years of experience in municipal government and has made significant changes to streamline operations and improve customer service to our community. The changes in town hall hours are honestly too soon to speak about, and we should reflect on this once they have been in place for six months to ensure these changes are beneficial and meet the needs of the public. Should they not we will look at them to decide how to move forward

4. What opportunities do you see for reducing long-term municipal operating costs?

There’s a great opportunity to collaborate with our CHARIHO partner towns to gain economies of scale in negotiating for supplies, equipment, road materials, licensing, and insurance to name a few. This would allow us to save money over the course of time and benefit all three towns.

5. How do you envision Richmond partnering with neighboring communities to share municipal facilities and services?

The town can establish collaborative partnerships with neighboring municipalities by sharing municipal infrastructure, streamlining public safety, and look into some joint administrative services. As stated in my answer to question 4, we can save money by collectively negotiating on purchasing equipment or IT systems for economies of scale. At our recent joint Tri town council meeting a few months back, I raised this very point and asked our town administrators and town finance directors from the three CHARIHO towns to begin the process to do exactly this. We expect a report on this before the end of the year.

6. What differentiates you as a candidate and if elected, what will be your top priority during your term?

I believe that Jeff Marlowe, Shannock Mill Project, LLC lead, said it best: “I have found Councilman Palmisciano to be accessible, thoughtful and committed to serving the residents of Richmond. His positive energy and leadership support efforts that strengthen our community. We all gain from his reelection.” Top priorities will be seeing CHARIHO

Plaza re-developed. I worked behind the scenes for nine months with the parent company of Stop & Shop, conducting over 25 meetings, which resulted in them vacating their lease. I’m now working with the property owner to ensure that this critical piece of property in Richmond has a Renaissance. It will be developed in accordance with the needs of our community and the look and feel of our small town. I want to see it through. This goal ties directly into my other priorities of driving economic investment in our town and restoring a sense of pride in our downtown area. I will continue to work on legislation that puts the needs of our community first. I successfully drafted and secured approval for Rhode Island’s very first “No-Knock Registry,” giving you the power to legally block unsolicited door-to-door salespeople from interrupting your evenings. I will also be working with Councilor Madnick to ensure the progress already made to develop Richmond Commons continues.

7. Yes/No: Will you support housing developments that do not threaten our water resources, include required affordable housing units and hold developers responsible long term?

Yes



Justin K Price
Republican

1. What are the most important priorities when balancing economic development, environmental protection and rural character?

My top priority would be to facilitate a comprehensive plan that values input from the citizens. Once the plan is agreed upon, the council will implement the plan.

2. What approach would you take to evaluate new commercial development proposals?

The first question is: Does this development meet the comprehensive plan? Decisions based on a shared vision with the town and the developer will always make sense.

3. How do you think the recent changes in staffing and town hall hours have improved the efficiency and effectiveness of town government? What if any additional changes would you suggest?

(improvement? Yes? No?) These changes have just recently been implemented. I will need some time in service before I can form an opinion as to the efficiency and effectiveness. I am in favor of efficiency but want that to be balanced with safety and service. Economic development will be key in affording those priorities.

4. What opportunities do you see for reducing long-term municipal operating costs?

I would be in favor of studies that guide cost reductions. I think the town council should review the town’s yearly audited financial statement. This review is necessary in order to make informed decisions about town expenses.

5. How do you envision Richmond partnering with neighboring communities to share municipal facilities and services?

If this can achieve cost savings and meet all laws and regulations, I would be in favor.

6. What differentiates you as a candidate and if elected, what will be your top priority during your term?

Experience. I was a state representa-

tive for 8 years. I will bring that experience and knowledge to the local level. My top priority is to support the rural character of our town while balancing smart economic development. This will enhance the quality of life and services to our residents. I will make informed decisions that will benefit the present and future citizens of the town of Richmond.

As always I will base my decisions on presented sound information, valuable input from our citizens, advise from legal council and a full understanding of the topic.

7. Yes/No: Will you support housing developments that do not threaten our water resources, include required affordable housing units and hold developers responsible long term?

No response

Make a Voting Plan

1. Check your registration.
2. Decide how you will vote.
3. Find your polling place.
4. Review your ballot.
5. Learn about the candidates and issues.
6. Follow through. Cast your vote.



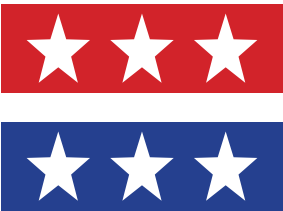
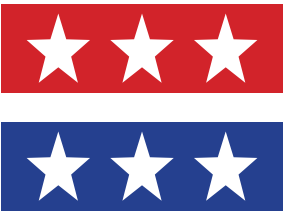
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RI Secretary of State



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Richmond General Election Candidates

RICHMOND TOWN COUNCIL



Mark T. Reynolds
Democrat

1. What are the most important priorities when balancing economic development, environmental protection and rural character?

To properly balance these competing interests we must follow Richmond’s Comprehensive Community Plan. This document is required by state law and established with input from a variety of sources. Richmond’s Comprehensive plan includes an overview of the town’s natural and cultural resources, economic conditions, housing and more. The plan lays out goals, policies and actions for natural and cultural resources that will allow Richmond to maintain its rural character, as well as goals and actions for economic development, housing, and

infrastructure. An important priority for maintaining Richmond’s rural character is keeping industrial scale solar out of forested areas. We must maintain our current zoning ordinance that limits solar to areas zoned for general business, industrial, and flex tech. The comprehensive plan balances economic development, environmental protection and rural character in the Future Land Use section. The plan designates those areas best suited for economic growth, single and multi-family housing, and other uses. Essentially the town needs to focus its commercial development efforts in the existing commercial area along Route 138 and areas designated for future development, such as Richmond Commons. This area is served by public water and its proximity to the highway makes it most suitable for additional businesses. The Richmond Rural Land Trust itself and through collaboration with groups like the Nature Conservancy can continue to not just conserve property from development, but provide access to those properties for recreational opportunities. This serves the dual purpose of maintaining rural character while providing opportunities for economic development through eco-tourism.

2. What approach would you take to evaluate new commercial development proposals?

It is important to understand that the Town Council does not approve new development proposals, unless they require an amendment to the zoning ordinances. Nevertheless, for me an ideal commercial development proposal is one that is situated in the area of town that has been designated for future commercial development. Also, it would be preferable for new commercial development to

be a source of employment for Richmond residents and/or be a source of goods/ services for residents. A good commercial development would have limited impact on the community and not involve excessive noise or odors and not result in disruption to residents’ routines. A commercial business owner that sees the town as a partner/collaborator and that intends to be involved in the community is preferred.

3. How do you think the recent changes in staffing and town hall hours have improved the efficiency and effectiveness of town government? What if any additional changes would you suggest?

It is difficult to assess the impact of these changes because they have only been in effect for a short time during the summer months. The changes will also make the government more effective by better meeting resident needs through expanded hours. I have already heard from residents that have utilized the additional hours to access services that they were unable to with the previous hours. I believe the changes will make town government more effective and efficient by improving staff attendance. Closing Town Hall one day allows staff to take care of personal business and appointments without having to take time off from work. Also, the four day week makes it easier to keep all departments properly staffed to serve residents. The schedule change will result in the town saving money through the use of part time staff and lower utility costs. Most staff were in favor of the new schedule, so hopefully the change will help limit staff turnover.

4. What opportunities do you see for reducing long-term municipal operating

costs?

Since being on Town Council we have engaged in a detailed review of budget line items and spending to make sure costs are contained. Investing a small amount in energy efficiency upgrades to our facilities will result in long term savings on utility and fuel costs. We also must look for staff efficiencies wherever possible. Following through with capital improvement plans will reduce repair and maintenance costs. Examples are new DPW equipment, and modernizing buildings like Town Hall and Police Station/Community Center. I will make sure the town is searching for funding either through grants or the state to supplement our town budget to continue with the repaving efforts to avoid incurring debt.

5. How do you envision Richmond partnering with neighboring communities to share municipal facilities and services?

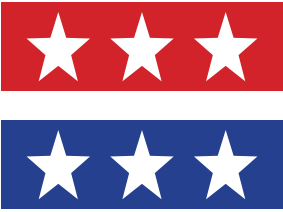
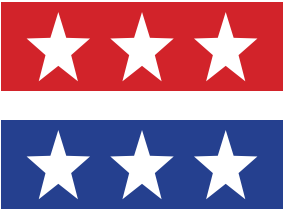
Richmond recently took a step in this process through the tri-town meeting of Town Councils. We should continue regular tri-town meetings to discuss opportunities for collaboration. We can expand our Department of Public Works sharing equipment with neighboring towns by having neighboring towns develop a list of equipment that each has available to share. There are also opportunities to share some specialized staff that a single town cannot afford or doesn’t need on a full time basis. This could include inspectors, engineers, and/or grant writers. Another opportunity for collaboration could involve transportation and activities for seniors.

6. What differentiates you as a candidate and if elected, what will be your top priority during your term?

As an attorney I have a unique perspective that enables me to analyze proposed changes to our ordinances and proposals that come before the Town Council. I also have extensive work/life experiences. I am a small business owner, unlike almost all of the other candidates. I have also held volunteer leadership positions for the Ocean Community YMCA (OCY). I served on the OCY Board for 9 years and was Chief Volunteer Officer of OCY from 2022-2024. I have also served on the Arcadia Y Branch Board for more than 15 years. I have volunteered extensively within our community supporting our youth through Chariho Little League, Chariho Youth Soccer Association, and Scout Troop 1 Richmond. My top priorities if elected will be continuing efforts to facilitate redevelopment of Chariho Plaza and collaborate with the developer of Richmond Commons. I will work to have open lines of communication with local businesses to understand their needs and how the town can assist them. I will focus on developing responsible budgets that limit spending increases while improving the town’s infrastructure through road repaving and a preventative road maintenance program. Finally I will work to expand recreational opportunities for residents. This includes continuing development at 4 Richmond Townhouse and developing indoor and outdoor facilities on the forty acre recreational area the developer of Richmond Commons has designated for town.

7. Yes/No: Will you support housing developments that do not threaten our water resources, include required affordable housing units and hold developers responsible long term?

Yes



Richmond General Election Candidates

RICHMOND SCHOOL COMMITTEE



Patrick Farrell
Democrat

1. Civics is now required to graduate high school in RI. What do you think should be the balance between U.S. History, the country’s founding principles, and hands-on civic engagement?

For six years, I was part of a team of faculty that led students on a week-long community service trip to South Carolina. This adventure convinced me of how powerful experiential learning and community engagement can be in providing students with a transformative educational experience. However, for students to understand the lessons offered by hands-on civic engagement, they must be aware of key aspects of our nation’s history. The teaching of that history should include our country’s founding principles and its deep and

complex cultural history. As a life-long teacher, I think the specifics on this question are best considered in conjunction with Chariho’s history and social science teachers for they can take into account a students’ grade level/prior exposure as well as guidelines supplied by the Rhode Island Department of Education.

2. If pressed to reduce the budget bottom line, what specific cuts would you be willing to vote for and why?

My work experience included serving as Dean of Faculty and Director of Summer Session. In these roles, I learned how difficult it can be to prioritize choices when faced with limited funds. I also saw how even the best of plans must be adapted when unforeseen challenges arise. If cuts need to be made, we should limit those cuts that would negatively impact learning or the student experience. At all times, we should be guided by the belief that an investment in our young people is an investment in the future health and vitality of our towns. For a group of 12 people (i.e. the Chariho School Committee) to take on challenging issues concerning spending on schools, each school committee member must be willing to listen, learn, collaborate and compromise. With that thought in mind, naming specific cuts prior to entering discussions with my colleagues on the school committee would, I fear, be counterproductive.

3. The district’s fund balance has fallen to about 2% of the operating budget, well below the 5–7% auditors recommend for appropriate emergency response. What would you propose to do about it?

The fund balance issue must be

addressed as it has a direct effect on our ability to handle the unforeseen crises that will inevitably arise. I would advocate we do so responsibly by upping that percentage gradually. For example, if we increase the fund balance by 1.5% for the next three years, we can get to a district fund balance percentage of 6.5% by 2029. In addition, we must understand the circumstances that led to this situation. Older school buildings (like our three elementary schools) come with increased and often unexpected maintenance costs. This is one reason that I fully support the proposed \$116 million bond referendum to replace the district’s three aging elementary schools on one elementary campus.

4. What qualities do you value in a superintendent and what criteria would you use to evaluate one? No names, please.

Educators are in the business of personal growth. While classroom teachers focus on the personal growth of their students, the leader of a school district must support the growth of students, teachers, support staff and administrators. With that thought in mind, I value a superintendent with:

- Strong communication skills (including the ability to connect with students, parents, teachers, support staff administrators and members of the school committee).
- A vision for the future of the Chariho schools and a plan for how to get us there.
- Integrity and accountability with an eye toward continuous improvement.
- Empathy so that all the members of the Chariho community feel they are seen and appreciated.

The school committee should use objective criteria to measure these aspects of leadership:

- Student growth and achievement.

- Fiscal management and operations.
- Board governance and relations.
- Personnel management.
- Community engagement.

5. What are three things you would like to see the Chariho Regional School District do differently and why?

As with the question about budgets, putting forth bold statements for change without first hearing the thoughts of my colleagues on the school committee is not consistent with my philosophy of listening, learning and working collaboratively. With those words of caution, I do think the district needs to be more mindful of the long term impact of the decisions we make in the present. For example, voting to not extend a superintendent’s term without doing the legally required evaluation first will likely deter others from applying to fill that position in the future. Another example of problematic short-term thinking is believing that we can simply repair the current elementary schools indefinitely – the next school committee must do all it can to inform voters that the only responsible way forward is to build new schools. As a final example, all schools in our nation are finding it hard to create policy that keeps up with rapid technological advances. We failed to see the harm that cell phones would cause our young people, and a similar dynamic is now at play regarding artificial intelligence. The Chariho School Committee must always make emerging technologies and the future an integral part of present-day discussions. The school committee’s proposed review of Chromebook use in early grades is an example of where I’m glad to see the schools and community looking at how technologies impact learning.

6. What differentiates you as a can-

didate and if elected, what will be your top priority during your term?

I have 43 years of experience as a teacher and administrator. I’ve taught math, hired (and sometimes fired) teachers, evaluated instructors and managed budgets. At the Maine School of Science and Mathematics, I was the first teacher hired and learned a great deal about creating and maintaining a high-quality educational environment for young people. That experience reinforced my belief that a school system - teachers, administrators, support staff students, parents, school committee people and community members - must function like a team, with each member having a shared responsibility for the work and the outcomes. We all have a role to play and each of us must support one another in our efforts to maintain an outstanding school system. One of my top priorities is to help the members of the school committee, the school’s senior administration, and people in the Chariho community realize that if we want our students to grow up to be responsible citizens, we must model that behavior in all that we say and do as adults. If we keep this in mind, we’ll be able to find effective solutions to problems that come our way. And we’ll do so in a manner that is consistent with the school system’s motto of “all kids – all of the time.” Let’s come together to build a strong, supportive and resilient educational community for Chariho!

7. Yes/No: I fully support the proposed \$116 million bond referendum to replace the district’s three aging elementary schools on one elementary campus?

Yes



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Richmond General Election Candidates



RICHMOND SCHOOL COMMITTEE



David Lelli
Republican

1. Civics is now required to graduate high school in RI. What do you think should be the balance between U.S. History, the country's founding principles, and hands-on civic engagement?

Our founding principles must provide the basis for civics instruction, around which U.S. History and civic engagement may be undertaken in context. Students must first realize, as our founding fathers did, the self-evidence of our God given rights of life and liberty, not to be abridged by any government. The founders also recognized moral law, given by the same Creator to all in the form of conscience or a sense of justice and mercy as well as the need for a government. They crafted one that would serve the people, protecting their rights, and not exist to be served. Thus, we have a constitutional republic such as has never been; a government of, by and for the people. It is through the lens of understanding these principles that students can gain a fresh perspective on our history. Most

often our successes as a nation came because we worked together, remembering our founding principles, and our failures were when we forgot them.

Our government will only work if an enlightened people are consistently involved. That's where civic engagement comes in. Students can see our government in action by attending and participating in town hall meetings or discussions of bills at the state house or by volunteering in the community.

Civics instruction is vital to the formation of enlightened young citizens. It will be of immeasurable benefit to our society if we can teach our young people the true meaning of one nation under God, indivisible, with liberty and justice for all.

2. If pressed to reduce the budget bottom line, what specific cuts would you be willing to vote for and why?

The Chariho budget is rife with excess spending on unnecessary programs with courses that do not lead students to be ready to enter the workplace upon graduation. I would take a critical look at all such programs that may fit this description and make the difficult decisions where necessary to cut the worst of them. Too many students graduate high school with little to no idea of what they want to do and without skills necessary to compete in the workplace. They attend a college where they can spend years in academia, coming out with a great amount of debt and still no marketable skills. I would emphasize vocational training at all levels of primary and secondary education. Encouragement toward vocational training will inspire students and can give them the necessary skills for the workplace right upon graduation versus liberal arts instruction that fails them. Furthermore, I would take a critical look at teachers, their salaries and performance reviews, and make decisions to rehire and give pay increases based upon merit and not on seniority. We have become too beholden to the teachers unions, which do not serve the interests of the best and most dedicated teachers or incentivize young teachers to aspire to excellence.

3. The district's fund balance has fallen to about 2% of the operating budget, well below the 5-7% auditors recommend for appropriate emergency response. What would you propose to do about it?

When a fund balance goes this low, an institution loses credit rating and is less enabled to invest in new initiatives. For a school department, this can stifle growth and ability to meet the needs of the children and their families. Our technical school at the high school is the best in the state. It could be made even greater to serve the needs of a society that is desperately seeking trade skills. It is a shame that those in charge of our school department have let our resources slip to this level and leave us in such a position. In addition to the budget cuts that I cited above, I would recommend fund raiser ideas to support our schools. One of the planks of my platform is to have active engagement in the education of our students by the public, especially businesses large and small. The more open to the public our education system is, the more people will take interest in and want to be a part of its success because people are inherently generous. The business community has a vested interest in the quality education of the children, but they also have an interest in marketing and promoting themselves as having community consciousness. So, because of that they will be more apt to engage in helping local schools. Sports and entertainment venues could be a great way to bring dollars to Chariho and give local businesses a chance to advertise at the same time.

4. What qualities do you value in a superintendent and what criteria would you use to evaluate one? No names, please.

A superintendent needs to have many of the attributes of a successful small business owner. Such a person, first and foremost, needs to be a good leader, with ability to disseminate their vision to all who work for and with them and inspire them with their own drive and passion.

A prospective superintendent like a good business owner needs to relate to people, both within the organization and with the public, meeting their needs collectively and individually with courtesy, kindness and patience toward all. A prospective superintendent like a good business owner needs to be financially and fiscally adept, balancing thrift with sound investment. Finally, a prospective superintendent like a good business owner needs have the ability to weather disappointments and setbacks and to take successes in stride, always moving forward with persistence. If you think about it, everything required of a good superintendent is mirrored in the qualities of a successful and beloved business owner. The traits of being a good leader with real world experience are much more important for a prospective superintendent than whatever academic background they may have. This is not to say that a superintendent must necessarily have started and grown a private business. But the more aspects of business ownership they have experienced success with, the greater their chance of their being successful in leading a school district.

5. What are three things you would like to see the Chariho Regional School District do differently and why?

I would first call for complete public transparency within the Chariho School District. There should be no secrets whatsoever in what or how our children are being taught. This is public education and the school department is meant to serve the taxpaying public. With full transparency, there is boundless mutual benefit for all, except maybe for the teachers unions and the educational establishment. Too bad for them. The interests of students and their families must be put first. All students all the time.

Secondly, I believe it takes a village to raise a child. This is a unique idea, but I would call for direct collaboration between interested teachers and willing public for assisting in instruction. There is a vast wealth of knowledge and experience within the public that a conscientious teacher could tap into, augmenting

his/her classroom instruction with real world application. Such a partnership would empower teachers, inspire students and engage the public for the benefit of all.

Finally, I would propose that all Chariho bonds must pass in all three towns and not just by majority of the district. One town should not be able to override the will of the entire district as has happened. It is the onus of the school committee to craft a bond that will have a good chance of success in all three towns and not just say "OK, we know Charlestown will be overwhelmingly for this bond, so let's just do it". That's unfair. Chariho united, or not at all.

6. What differentiates you as a candidate and if elected, what will be your top priority during your term?

My top priority as a school committee member will be to serve the best interests of the families of Chariho and not the interests of the educational establishment. As I stated above, the purpose of our government is to serve and not to be served. Children are the treasure of our society and families are the basic units of that society. Every policy in the Chariho School District must support, encourage and nurture families, and certainly not create any divisions or conflicts between children and their parents. Parents or guardians have authority over their children and must be allowed to raise them as they see fit. This is a part of natural law as cited above. No school district should be able to abridge these rights of parents but instead must support and help guide them as best as possible. As a member of the school committee, I would scrutinize at all policies and amend those that fall short of fully recognizing parental rights and supporting those rights completely and honestly.

7. Yes/No: I fully support the proposed \$116 million bond referendum to replace the district's three aging elementary schools on one elementary campus?

No



Andrew A. McCoy
Democrat

1. Civics is now required to graduate high school in RI. What do you think should be the balance between U.S. History, the country's founding principles, and hands-on civic engagement?

It is very important to understand the founding principles of our nation, especially the parts where the principles

are greater than the men that wrote them. Our Founding principles show that only through engagement can our country continue to be a great nation. Hands-on civics engagement is what has always made our country great, specifically the first amendment allowing criticism of the government. It's only through such criticism that our country has moved forward and fixed sins of the past, i.e. slavery and not allowing women to vote. Without understanding our founding principles, there wouldn't be any true understanding of why hands-on civics is required to continue having a great nation.

The current proposed social studies curriculum for Chariho High School graduates has a large section on understanding civics in our nation as well being able to engage in appropriate discourse about our institutions and community service.

2. If pressed to reduce the budget bottom line, what specific cuts would you be willing to vote for and why?

There is almost no 'fluff' in the Chariho budget to make major cuts. The core curriculum teaching reading, writing, and mathematics must be kept strong at the elementary/ middle school levels. Almost all educational achievement is dependent on these being strong at the early levels of education. Chariho High School and Chariho Tech School offer spectacular diverse educational opportunities for our children, any major cuts

would be detrimental to the community as a whole. Deferred maintenance only begets further increased spending down the road, so should only be considered in extreme circumstances. Extracurriculars would be the only immediate place that cuts could come from in my opinion, anything else would require a lot of searching and compromise to find cuts without compromising our excellent schools.

Although in my opinion, extracurriculars are very important for students to get the most out of their High School career and are simply the cost of having a good educational institution.

3. The district's fund balance has fallen to about 2% of the operating budget, well below the 5-7% auditors recommend for appropriate emergency response. What would you propose to do about it?

There's no magic for this one, you just have to chip away at it. Increasing the balance slowly over several years, 1/2% to 1% per year, until it's up to acceptable levels is the most prudent way to address the issue. This will ensure if we do have any major issues crop up the district isn't forced to have major tax increases to cover one off events.

4. What qualities do you value in a superintendent and what criteria would you use to evaluate one? No names, please.

A superintendent has a huge and varied list of responsibilities. They are responsible for every aspect of caring for our school district. It is easy to criticize without understanding the balance the superintendent must achieve.

The first criteria will always be student achievement. This includes test scores and graduation rates. There should be enough data to determine strong and weak areas of our schools' teaching to reinforce weak areas while maintaining strengths.

The second is operational management of the school. School safety, proper school lunches, maintenance, staffing decisions and staff morale all come under this umbrella.

Financial management of the above people and resources is required of all superintendents. Are audits regularly showing proper use of district funds?

Community outreach and relations are necessary as well. Having a positive relationship with the community is very valuable to get good response to school initiatives. Trust is important, it keeps parents and educators on the same side.

Professional ethics, having high standards, integrity and honesty should be a given for anyone in such a position.

5. What are three things you would like to see the Chariho Regional School District do differently and why?

Better elementary school facilities are

desperately needed. Hopefully the school bond referendum passes so we can have an appropriate school for our students.

Free student lunches would ensure all students can have a healthy lunch without regard to parent income. Proper nutrition directly affects student concentration, academic performance, and attendance rates.

Better after school care programs for working families. The benefits include improved academics, social development, higher attendance, not to mention the value it would provide to the working families of the district.

6. What differentiates you as a candidate and if elected, what will be your top priority during your term?

What sets me apart as a candidate is that I care about all the students and want to ensure every student gets a top notch education.

My top priority as a candidate is to ensure we have excellent and safe schools for our students. This doesn't require extravagant spending; this requires good people and good facilities that are held to high expectations.

7. Yes/No: I fully support the proposed \$116 million bond referendum to replace the district's three aging elementary schools on one elementary campus?

Yes



Hopkinton General Election Candidates



HOPKINTON TOWN COUNCIL



Kevin G. Lambert
Democrat

1. What do you believe are the three most challenging issues facing Hopkinton over the next two years and why are they important to you ?

Firstly, reducing our high property

taxes is probably the most challenging issue in the town. To reduce them we either need to raise revenue or reduce expenditures. Hopkinton doesn't have town water or septic which are both requirements to attract businesses which is the most straightforward way to raise revenue which leaves lowering expenditures. The town should look into installing solar panels onto government buildings to reduce our long term costs. We need to continue to work together with Richmond and Charlestown to continue finding ways that our towns can reduce our expenditures. Next is that various companies keep attempting to start new solar projects even though new projects are not allowed in Hopkinton. This was recently attempted by the developer attempting to convert the Brushy Brook project from housing to large-scale solar. I will not approve any large scale solar projects which include the cutting down of our forests or the destruction of habitats. The town council needs to keep a watchful eye on how state mandates could be used to try to force us to allow more solar projects. The town needs to also work with our business owners to help them install rooftop solar if they choose to. Lastly the town needs to work to ensure that our drinking water sources stay uncontaminated. Residents who wish to need to have a clear way to get their personal wells tested for PFAS or other contaminants.

2. What economic policies or practices would you support to protect Hopkinton's water resources and forests, specifically in relation to large solar and data centers?

The town's hands are tied on any solar projects which passed before restrictions were put into place. All we can realistically do is attempt to enforce all environmental standards to keep them from further harming the environment. I will do everything I can to keep data centers out of Hopkinton. I've spent my career in software development and IT and fully understand that data centers require massive amounts of power and water, neither of which do we have in abundance.

3. Today, school funding for CHARIHO is almost 80% of the total Hopkinton town annual budget. What will you do to expand services to taxpayers while maintaining our high-ranking education system?

The most straightforward way to expand services is to ensure work that the requirements for usage of the town's community center was finalized. It is currently a mess of various people saying that, what is supposed to be a community center, isn't usable by all of the commu-

nity. The policies need to be clarified and opened up wherever possible. It is ridiculous that there are restrictions on who in town can use it.

4. How should Hopkinton respond to state-mandated requirements that conflict with local regulations and citizens' concerns?

Hopkinton needs to work with other towns throughout the state as a group to apply pressure through our representatives against state mandates which ignore local issues. For example the state has mandated a 10% threshold for affordable housing while forcing comprehensive permits which restrict how each city and town can meet the threshold.

5. What specific steps would you take to improve communication, trust, and civic engagement between the Town Council and the public?

I have heard a number of times recently that residents don't know when special votes are occurring or what is happening at the town council meetings. A simple step would be to create business cards with a QR code pointing at the town's website. There should be an emailable newsletter which is an amalgamation of what is coming up, le board meeting dates and agendas, town council meeting

dates and agendas, etc along with if there are any open competitive bids, what construction projects are ongoing and other related information.

6. What differentiates you as a candidate and if elected, what will be your top priority during your term?

I am an Eagle Scout who still believes in the scout law. I am a volunteer with Save One Soul Animal Rescue League and believe that goodness can come in small packages. I have spent the last 30+ years in software development and over my career I have learned to break problems down so that they are more manageable for people, including myself to deal with. The ability to do that is a defining characteristic of software development. I have used that ability outside of my professional life and into volunteering. It was useful to various extents throughout my scouting career, for example by helping increase the packs profits from selling popcorn, and would be extremely useful as a town councilor.

7. Yes/No: Will you support housing developments that do not threaten our water resources, include required affordable housing units and hold developers responsible long term?

Yes



Be Sure to Vote on Tuesday, November 3, 2026.



Hopkinton General Election Candidates

HOPKINTON TOWN COUNCIL



Sylvia K. Thompson
Independent

1. What do you believe are the three most challenging issues facing Hopkinton over the next two years and why are they important to you ?

I would address the three most challenging issues facing Hopkinton as follows:

Expand our tax base with economic development that is resident supported. Change the Chariho Act to require all school bonds be equally paid with each Town paying 1/3, change the formula used to fund Chariho and scrutinize the town and school budgets.

The Hope Valley School is part of the Hope Valley Water Line District (HVWLD), and cannot be used as affordable housing or any overnight activities. State and Town restrictions would apply because the HVWLD has documented environmental restrictions and is in a flood plain.

If the Hope Valley School is no longer used for school purposes, I have pro-

posed the town consider selling it to an investment company that would buy the school for Incubator businesses.

An incubator business is an organization or program that helps new startups and early entrepreneurs grow. The main goal is to help a young business survive their first stage and build a strong path to success. This would expand our tax base.

For example, two vacant school buildings in Connecticut were sold to investment companies for incubators purposes. The Town of Ledyard's school was sold to Florian Properties and it is being repurposed for this purpose.

Currently we have vacant commercial buildings. Working cooperatively with our Economic Development Commission we can open those buildings with new businesses.

2. What economic policies and practices would I support to protect Hopkinton's water resources and forests, specifically in relation to solar and data centers?

I will propose the town develop an ordinance that will regulate clear cutting large tracts of forests and propose we prohibit data centers in all zones.

I will respect the below designations to ensure neighborhoods are not impacted or support developers that submit waivers to try to get around these requirements.

As a member of the Wood Pawcatuck Watershed Association (WPWS), we worked as a team with environmental organizations securing the Sole Source Aquifer designation.

Our council actively supported the Wild and Scenic River designation for the Wood and Pawcatuck Rivers to protect local water quality, and wildlife habitats without altering private property rights.

In the nineties, we wrote the first comprehensive plan, created the district use table, and established the Planning Board. This was a labor-intensive endeavor. We needed to understand each activity allowed in order to protect our water, forests, rural character, and

neighborhoods.

When I was re-elected in 2006 serving until 2019, we worked cooperatively with the Planning Board and residents to revise the Comp Plan and District Use Table.

We supported the Hopkinton Land Trust by including warrant items (a bond) in the Town's budget. Allowing the voters to decide for open space for trails and recreation.

For 22 years I was very involved in providing input to amend the Comp Plan. For instance, I was able to insert protections for the Hope Valley area, wrote amendments prohibiting new gas stations and wind turbines in all zones. All passed.

3. Today, school funding for CHARIHO is almost 80% of the total Hopkinton town annual budget. What will you do to expand services to taxpayers, while maintaining our high-ranking education system?

I wouldn't call Chariho a high-ranking education system. Except the elementary schools are exceptional. However, I did receive an excellent education from Chariho and URI. I credit the dedication and support of the teachers and staff. However, being tough on the school budget is not anti-education, but doing your job.

However, changing the Act will end the fighting over the budget and allow the school committee to move forward and improve educational opportunities.

Chariho's budget takes 79% of our budget because we have 3 different school tax rates.

The property tax rate has 2 parts. A rate for the school and one for the town. Using previous school tax rates, please consider the following:

Charlestown's school tax rate was \$2.77. Richmond's was \$11.736.

Hopkinton's was \$12.079. This means a property assessed for \$500,00 in Charlestown paid \$1,385.50. Richmond paid \$5,868. Hopkinton paid \$6,039.50.

The Chariho Act, created in 1958 was

approve by State Legislators. Current regional school districts learned from our flawed Act and instead uses a special state formula, the Adjusted Equalized Weighted Assessment Valuation, (AE-WAV).

The AEWAV state formula considers a town's total value, median income, etc.

Since the Legislators created the Chariho Act, they have the legal authority to change it. I propose they require all school bonds be paid equally with each town paying 1/3, and require fairness by using the AEWAV formula. Like every other regional school district in RI.

4. How should Hopkinton respond to state-mandated requirements that conflict with local regulations and citizens' concerns?

If elected, I would respond to state mandated requirements that conflict with our zoning and local regulations by how we did during my 11 terms on the Council. We detailed our opposition, notified the League of Cities and Towns, every city and town, every RI Legislator, involved our residents, attended state hearings, and protested.

If elected, I will write an amendment to prohibit data centers townwide in every zone. Solar is already prohibited and I agree. We have done enough.

5. What specific steps would you take to improve communication, trust, and civic engagement between the Town Council and the public?

As a member of the Town Council, I will respond to resident concerns, hold community meetings, add items to the agenda, and thoroughly explain my votes or answers.

When I was elected in the 90's, we were the second town (behind Westerly) to video our council meetings. Residents could view meetings on their television.

Residents can still view council meetings on television, via You Tube, or on the Town's website.

6. What differentiates you as a candidate and if elected, what will be your top priority during your term?

Experience. I have served the town for 30 years. I chaired the Town's Water Study Committee, Tax Board of Review, currently the 250th Commission, and as member of the Chariho District Finance Committee representing our town. I was re-elected 11 times for Town Council. I also served on non-profits, South County Community Action, the WPWS, and the WARM Shelter that I co-founded.

I love our town. I grew up on a dairy farm in Hope Valley and learned the value of hard work. I will be straight with you, scrutinize town and Chariho budgets, do my homework, and never waste a dime.

I have always been a conservative Democrat. However, I am now an independent because the Hopkinton Democratic Town Committee drinks the Chariho cool aid. I never did or will.

In 1987 I completed a comprehensive study of the village of Hope Valley. I identified lots without septs and failed systems, and the number of apartments in each lot.

The solution, I wrote Hopkinton's first Community Block Grant that established the Home Repair Program. Septic systems were repaired and installed townwide as well as home repairs.

In 1991, I was directed to do everything needed to extend the Richmond Water Line into the village of Hope Valley. I secured grants, completed an environmental study, (without taxpayer funds) and jumped through every hoop a multitude of state departments required.

I know who to call when something goes sideways and who to call when we don't have answers.

7. Yes/No: Will you support housing developments that do not threaten our water resources, include required affordable housing units and hold developers responsible

No



Richard P. Wucik, Jr.
Democrat

1. What do you believe are the three most challenging issues facing Hopkinton over the next two years and why are they important to you ?

Hopkinton is at a pivotal crossroads, and the decisions we make over the next two years will shape our town's identity for a generation. As a candidate for Town Council, I am focused on three critical challenges: restoring transparency, protecting our landscape from industrial solar development, and strategically expanding our business tax base.

First, we must prioritize Transparency. Local government functions best when built on a foundation of trust. I am committed to open communication and ensuring residents are heard before decisions are finalized. By providing clear, accessible information, we can ensure every neighbor understands the reasoning behind council actions and move forward as a unified community.

Second, we must take a firm stand against Large-Scale Solar Development. Our rural character and expansive forests are the heart of Hopkinton. Allowing industrial-sized solar arrays to clear-cut our woods threatens the environment that draws people to our town. I will work to protect our natural resources and ensure that energy initiatives do not come at the

expense of our community's beauty or quality of life.

Finally, we need to Increase Business Development. Currently, the tax burden falls too heavily on residential property owners. To provide relief while maintaining essential services, we must proactively recruit responsible commercial growth. By attracting businesses that fit our community's character, we can diversify our tax base and create a sustainable financial future.

By focusing on honesty in government, land preservation, and smart economic growth, we will ensure Hopkinton remains the special place to call home.

2. What economic policies or practices would you support to protect Hopkinton's water resources and forests, specifically in relation to large solar and data centers?

As a Town Council candidate, I am firm in my opposition to industrial-scale solar projects and data centers that require clear-cutting our forests or encroaching upon our vital watersheds. These developments offer short-term gains at the cost of long-term ecological and financial stability.

I advocate for a 'Conservation-First' zoning approach. This policy ensures that our town's planning map prioritizes the preservation of contiguous forest tracts and water recharge areas. By implementing significant impact fees, we can make industrial development in these sensitive zones cost-prohibitive, steering developers toward more appropriate locations.

Instead of sacrificing our green space, we should incentivize small-scale, rooftop, and brownfield solar. I support tax structures that reward residents and business owners for utilizing existing footprints, keeping our renewable energy goals aligned with our conservation values.

Protecting our environment is an economic necessity. Maintaining our forests and clean water is the most cost-effective way to preserve property values and avoid the staggering taxpayer costs associated with water infrastructure remediation. We don't have to choose between economic growth and environmental protection; by prioritizing our land and water, we ensure Hopkinton remains a desirable, sustainable place to live for generations to come."

3. Today, school funding for CHARIHO is almost 80% of the total Hopkinton town annual budget. What will you do to expand services to taxpayers while maintaining our high ranking education system?

Our school system is the heartbeat of Hopkinton. Its reputation for excellence is a primary reason people choose to call this town home, and it serves as a critical anchor for our property values. However, we cannot ignore the reality that when 80% of our budget is dedicated to a single area, it leaves very little room to provide the high-quality municipal services—such as infrastructure improvements, senior programs, and recreation—that our residents deserve.

My approach is not to subtract from our schools, but to add to our tax base. We must aggressively pursue responsible business development to shift the tax burden away from residential property owners. By attracting commercial partners that fit our town's unique character, we can generate the revenue needed to expand town services without asking our neighbors to pay more out of pocket. To be clear, this does not mean welcoming industrial solar or data centers that compromise our landscape; it means smart, intentional growth.

Simultaneously, we must ensure fiscal accountability through regional collaboration. I will advocate for efficiencies in school spending to ensure that every tax dollar is prioritized for the classroom and student outcomes. By growing our commercial sector and insisting on budgetary transparency, we can maintain our high-ranking educational standards while finally delivering the robust town services Hopkinton residents expect and deserve."

4. How should Hopkinton respond to state-mandated requirements that conflict with local regulations and citizens' concerns?

When state mandates clash with our local regulations, we shouldn't view it as a win-lose scenario. Instead, we should see it as a pivotal opportunity to modernize Hopkinton on our own terms. As someone who lives and breathes real estate every day, I know that resisting change entirely often leads to missed opportunities, while smart, proactive planning allows us to shape our future.

We need a seat at the table. By working

collaboratively with the state, we can ensure these mandates are implemented in a way that respects our unique rural character. My goal is to leverage my professional expertise to advocate for diverse housing options—like high-quality senior housing and attainable starter homes—that the market currently lacks.

Well-planned growth isn't just about new buildings; it's about the bottom line for every resident. By strategically expanding our tax base and increasing inventory, we can alleviate the individual tax burden and decrease housing costs, making Hopkinton more affordable for everyone, from young professionals to retirees.

I understand the concerns regarding our town's identity. That's why I am committed to total transparency. Every step of this process must be driven by community input, ensuring that as we grow, we do so with intention. We can satisfy state requirements while protecting what we love about our town—it just takes a professional, balanced approach to get it right.

5. What specific steps would you take to improve communication, trust, and civic engagement between the Town Council and the public?

Trust isn't built behind doors; it's built through transparency and consistent, open dialogue. As a local Realtor, my entire career is rooted in clear, timely communication and the ability to simplify complex processes for the people I serve. I intend to bring that same service-oriented mindset to the Town Council.

To bridge the gap between the Council and the public, I propose three actionable steps:

- Monthly Community Meetups: I will launch regular, informal Q&A sessions held in local community spaces. These sessions will allow for the kind of candid, two-way conversation that formal meetings often stifle.
- Digital-First Communication: I'll push for a proactive strategy utilizing real-time social media updates and a streamlined email newsletter. Residents shouldn't have to hunt for information on council agendas or major decisions.
- Citizen Advisory Committees: I want to give residents a direct seat at the table for projects involving land preservation and business development, ensuring community expertise is utilized. Engagement also requires accessibil-

ity. We must improve our live-streaming capabilities and consider rotating meeting locations across different neighborhoods to ensure everyone has the opportunity to participate. My goal is to move beyond the minimum requirements of public notice and foster a culture where residents feel heard, valued, and informed. By treating our neighbors like the vital stakeholders they are, we can build a town government that truly reflects the community it serves.

6. What differentiates you as a candidate and if elected, what will be your top priority during your term?

What differentiates me is a deep, connection to Hopkinton and Chariho area combined with a professional background in real estate that demands negotiation, clear communication, and results. While national politics is often defined by noise and chaos, I believe local government should be the exact opposite: neighbors helping neighbors. I am not running to advance a partisan agenda; I am running to ensure our town remains a place we are all proud to call home.

If elected, my top priority will be Protecting Hopkinton's Future through a focused, three-pronged approach:

- Transparency: Rebuilding trust by ensuring every resident feels heard and understands how decisions are made.
- No Industrial Solar or Data Centers: Preserving our rural character by opposing large-scale industrial projects that don't align with our town's landscape.
- Responsible Business Growth: Encouraging smart, sustainable commercial development that strengthens our tax base without compromising our quality of life.

My commitment is to listen first. As a real estate professional, I spend my days solving problems and finding common ground. I will bring that same dedication to the Town Council, focusing exclusively on Hopkinton's specific needs and the voices of the people who live here. I would be honored to earn your vote and work together to keep our community thriving.

7. Yes/No: Will you support housing developments that do not threaten our water? Absolutely.

Yes

Robert Boudreau - no response

Robert Burns - no response

Michael James Geary - no response

Scott Sutherland - opted out



YOUR  VOTE
Counts

VOTE EARLY

October 14, 2026 -
November 2, 2026



Hopkinton General Election Candidates

HOPKINTON SCHOOL COMMITTEE



Gregory J. Avedisian
Democrat

1. Civics is now required to graduate high school in RI. What do you think should be the balance between U.S. History, the country's founding principles, and hands-on civic engagement?

Civic life is a foundational part of US democracy. Our schools are central to preparing young people to understand the importance of active and responsible engagement in the civic life of their local, state, and national communities. A robust understanding of US history allows students to appreciate the revolutionary character of this country's founding prin-

ciples. Civic engagement gives students the opportunity to actively put those principles into practice. These three areas must overlap and inform each other in order to provide students the necessary background to become vital and engaged members of their communities.

2. If pressed to reduce the budget bottom line, what specific cuts would you be willing to vote for and why?

Chariho's extremely tight budget must be managed carefully, transparently, and with forethought. In similar scenarios across the country we have seen that these cuts end up coming from sports and the arts. With a current operating budget that is already extremely lean, I believe it is critical for the School Committee to keep the public informed in a timely fashion and to actively seek their input as both parents and taxpayers. School Committee members represent the students as well as parents and other taxpayers in their respective communities; students are first and foremost at the center of what the Committee does. As a School Committee member, I would commit myself to thinking creatively about preserving the key resources and auxiliary services that allow young learners to thrive as much as possible. I will seek direct input from students, parents, and others in the community and maintain open dialogue with my fellow Committee members. Cutting staff or faculty would be an absolutely last resort.

3. The district's fund balance has fallen to about 2% of the operating budget, well below the 5-7% auditors recommend for appropriate emergency

response. What would you propose to do about it?

We need to make a plan to gradually increase the fund balance to at least 4%. The current fund balance puts the district at risk of continuing to make poor financial choices. It is incumbent on the district to break these habits, especially of drawing from the fund balance to offset large changes in student enrollment. Ideally this plan would begin with the success of November's bond which would pave the way for the realization of a unified elementary school. The financial benefit of this decision may not be realized in the short term, but as a Committee member I would advocate for long-term planning such as this to lay the groundwork for more strategic planning school year by school year.

4. What qualities do you value in a superintendent and what criteria would you use to evaluate one? No names, please.

A successful superintendent must be a confident leader with the ability and interest in engaging all constituents: students, faculty, staff, parents, state officials, and beyond. They must have deep experience in education, executive leadership, and community engagement. Chariho, like all school districts, relies on its superintendent to have a vision that is inclusive of a diversity of experiences and the determination to make hard decisions in the best interest of all students. Diplomacy and tact are crucial in this position. In evaluating a superintendent, the School Committee should begin with state and federal policies and

best practices. In addition to a yearly review, the School Committee should commit itself to regular check-ins with the superintendent throughout the year. Consistent, transparent communication and feedback allows room for growth, learning, and ultimately success in a superintendent.

5. What are three things you would like to see the Chariho Regional School District do differently and why?

Commit to the current Elementary School five-year CIP and stop wasting money on developing new ones. Over \$2.5 million has been wasted in X years because past School Committees have not been able to successfully pass a five-year CIP. The Committee must stop robbing the fund balance and instead find a way to use a rolling average of student enrollment to soften the financial burden imposed on a town that may experience a larger increase in Year 1 students. I would like the committee to bring good and accurate information to the public and seek their engagement and the engagement of the three town councils, especially when developing the district budget. Finally, I would like the committee to commit to meeting twice a month. To try and accomplish the complex issues that face the committee is a disservice to the students, staff and the community.

6. What differentiates you as a candidate and if elected, what will be your top priority during your term?

I've served on the Chariho School Committee before, and I know what real transparency looks like. I'm a proud

Chariho resident and public servant, having also served on the Charlestown Town Council. Hopkinton's Town Council appointed me to the Chariho Building Committee to help oversee construction of new elementary schools, and I've stayed engaged in this district ever since. My kids attended Chariho elementary and middle schools, and I have been a proud, engaged Chariho resident for nearly 30 years - first in Charlestown and now in Hopkinton. I bring a wealth of practical knowledge not only of public service, but also 25-plus years of experience in construction. During my tenure on the town council we oversaw the construction of a police station and beach pavilions. This is the experience that I will bring when addressing the desperately needed elementary school capital improvements. I believe an investment in our schools is an investment in every generation that comes after us and I have the experience to help make that investment. I am a 5 years taxpaying homeowner in Ashaway on the verge of retirement, married to a retired wife on a fixed income, which gives me the insight of the families in Hopkinton and the seniors who are on fixed incomes. I'm running again because Hopkinton's kids deserve a School Committee member who brings real experience, real transparency, and a real commitment to fiscal responsibility to that table.

7. Yes/No: I fully support the proposed \$116 million bond referendum to replace the district's three aging elementary schools on one elementary campus?

Yes



Justin Bentley
Democrat

1. Civics is now required to graduate high school in RI. What do you think should be the balance between U.S. History, the country's founding principles, and hands-on civic engagement?

In my opinion, the balance, so to speak, is really quite simple - all three components listed above are crucial to the growth of students and citizens of this country. Each component should require equal and balanced emphasis. All students should receive a strong, foundational study in US history (all aspects, time periods, groups, etc.), the founding principles, and mandatory, hands-on civic engagement. These three areas are truly the pillars of citizenship in this country. I have zero hesitation in stating that a person cannot truly be an informed and involved citizen without a strong background in these three branches. Democracy is not a spectator sport.

2. If pressed to reduce the budget

bottom line, what specific cuts would you be willing to vote for and why?

This is an extremely uncomfortable question for me to answer. I am a highly data-driven, factual person and I struggle with vague, hypotheticals. My involvement, as a parent and taxpayer over the past several years at Chariho School Committee meetings has allowed me to (passively) be an observer of the budgetary process. It has given me the chance to study the budget and attempt to come up with solutions to concerns over an ever-tightening financial strain. However, given the very first precept listed on the "Chariho Basic Management Principles and Ethical Standards" states: "Recognize that the first and greatest concern must be the educational welfare of the students attending the public schools. Given this, I cannot blindly state what I would be willing to vote for without an extensive examination and study of how said cuts would impact the students of the district. Many school committee members before me have attempted to use a scalpel and go through the budget and find line items to cut and have struggled to do so. Students first and foremost, always. Whether cuts come from academic classes offered, staffing, or extracurriculars such as athletics, I cannot definitively state - without concrete financial details and impact studies - where and how I would vote for cuts.

3. The district's fund balance has fallen to about 2% of the operating budget, well below the 5-7% auditors recommend for appropriate emergency response. What would you propose to do about it?

The district's fund balance is also a crucial aspect of the district and its operations. Along with the annual budget, the fund balance is a financially critical puzzle piece of Chariho Public School's existence and function. Sadly, several previous school committees have "borrowed" extensively from the fund balance to pay for items outside of the taxpayer-approved budget. For

example, in the past year, the committee spent almost \$800,000 over and above the approved budget. Sadly, this is NOT what the fund balance is for. As stated, auditors recommend AT LEAST 5-7% (many opt for 8-10%!). In order to remedy our district's nearly "code red" fund balance emergency, we will have to put money back into the fund balance each year over the foreseeable future. I know that may not be what many people wish to hear but just as regular families must have some type of emergency savings to combat unforeseen situations, the school district and its taxpayers must do the same. The only way to do this is to contribute back into the proverbial well and not draw from it to overspend above and beyond budgets, as has happened again and again in years past. In short, we must set aside money, year after year, for the next several budgets until we reach an acceptable threshold.

4. What qualities do you value in a superintendent and what criteria would you use to evaluate one? No names, please.

Every superintendent should be articulate, informed, a critical thinker, a listener, and a problem solver. A superintendent must be articulate and able to openly communicate, through speaking, writing, and presentations, ideas, procedures, rules, regulations, and various other components of a district. As many know, there are many moving parts in a school district, many of which are not clear to residents/taxpayers. It is the superintendent's responsibility to clearly communicate. They must also be informed about all of the aforementioned rules and regulations, whether they are from the state, the towns, the Chariho Act itself, or district policies and procedures. Without a strong background here, a superintendent will flounder and be ineffective. Critical thinking and problem solving go hand-in-hand. Everyday, problems arise all over a school district. Be it pupils, personnel, infrastructure, financials, etc., a superintendent absolutely must be able to think critically

and come up with effective solutions to problems. Although not everyone will be pleased by the solutions, they must be as equitable and fair as possible. Finally, a superintendent absolutely must be a good listener to ALL parties - students, faculty/staff, parents, etc. A good listener makes for an informed and caring, critically thinking, problem solving superintendent. Note: there is currently an evaluation rubric that the current committee is examining and using in a haphazard manner to (informally?) evaluate the current superintendent. Clearly, this tool would need to be utilized, reviewed, and refined to emphasize and evaluate the above qualities of an effective superintendent.

5. What are three things you would like to see the Chariho Regional School District do differently and why?

1. Develop and implement a district-wide, unified infrastructure plan. Although we have worked diligently towards a solution to the aging elementary schools via the school bond (one failed, one in the pipeline for the ballot in 2026), it is important to note that we have spent millions of dollars in just studying and planning for these through their various phases of study and applications. This will help with state-funding as well. Note: we currently do not have a five year capital improvement plan which drastically limits state aid/reimbursement to the district.

2. Work on healing the current friction amongst the sitting school committee. Political ideologies, chaotic voting, squabbling amongst members, sudden resignations, etc. have caused the committee to be ineffective as guardians of education and student well being. A multi-pronged approach is needed - perhaps through professional development (some current members are ignorant to procedures, policies, etc.), holding members accountable for their actions and statements (both at meetings and on social media platforms), and perhaps holding more than once-per-month

meetings (expedite meeting efficiency so no topics are tabled or short-changed).

3. Finally, the budget process needs to be more streamlined. It is confusing given the current process: a proposed budget into an approved budget, into an adopted budget (presented to voters) into an adjusted budget, into an actual budget (what is spent in fiscal year). This makes for many misunderstandings and confusion amongst stakeholders. Transparency and understanding are all that residents and parents ask for.

6. What differentiates you as a candidate and if elected, what will be your top priority during your term?

I am the only candidate who was born, raised, educated, and am raising my current family solely in the Chariho district, all while being a seasoned veteran in education (26 years and counting!). This balanced, multi-view gives me phenomenally well-rounded views. I am a parent of Chariho students. I am a science educator (Westerly school district) with 19 years in high school, and 7 years in middle school. I am a life-long resident of Chariho and a taxpayer.

In essence, I wear a multitude of hats which will be highly beneficial to the decisions I will make on the school committee as I will listen to, care for, consider, and try to meet the needs of every stakeholder in the district. However, as I stated in a previous response, students are and always will be number one. Given this, my absolute top priority will be to ensure that ALL students have the opportunity to feel safe, welcomed, and challenged all while receiving a quality public education that sends them off into the real world, ready to be contributing, productive citizens.

7. Yes/No: I fully support the proposed \$116 million bond referendum to replace the district's three aging elementary schools on one elementary campus?

Yes



Catherine M. Giusti
Independent

1. Civics is now required to graduate high school in RI. What do you think should be the balance between U.S. History, the country's founding principles, and hands-on civic engagement?

Learning the history of our country is imperative to raising well-rounded students. Civics lessons should encompass all facets of learning so all students benefit. We have to be willing to recognize the difficult moments in our history and discuss how we can work together to make the country better. Hands-on civic engagement can be exciting if the teacher is well supported and has the resources needed. Students are great, and any opportunity they have to gain real-world civic-minded experience is a benefit to them and the community.

2. If pressed to reduce the budget bottom line, what specific cuts would you be willing to vote for and why?

When I served as a School Committee member, I did advocate to reduce the budget. What I'm unwilling to do is pretend that I somehow know what cuts to make better than the Superintendent and the Administration. They live and breathe this budget. A public-school budget has privacy and regulatory intricacies that most people don't understand. Re-

spectfully, answering this question with specifics is unfair to the process and to the changing needs of students and staff that occur with each budget cycle. I am committed to working with the Administration to make sure I understand why budgetary decisions were made, how resources are used, and how we can make sure we're being respectful of taxpayers.

3. The district's fund balance has fallen to about 2% of the operating budget, well below the 5-7% auditors recommend for appropriate emergency response. What would you propose to do about it?

All three member towns of Chariho have healthy fund balances, and Chariho needs one too. Chariho needs to have funds available to spend on emergencies. The fund balance shouldn't be used only to reduce next year's budget. Having an emergency fund to fix issues like a leak at an elementary school, a failing playground, or plowing fees is a necessity, not a luxury. School Committee members need to commit to slowly building the fund balance back up to a reasonable amount. I'd like to see the fund balance at 3-5% each year.

4. What qualities do you value in a superintendent and what criteria would

you use to evaluate one? No names, please.

Our community deserves a Superintendent who is smart, hard-working, and puts students first. A good Superintendent needs to know education law, have financial acumen, and know they can rely on their team. No superintendent leads in a vacuum. They must be willing to explain why they make the decisions they do and make sure we give our public-school students an excellent education. Listening to the community, staff, and students while also making hard decisions is a balancing act. Chariho deserves a staunch public education advocate.

5. What are three things you would like to see the Chariho Regional School District do differently and why?

I'd like a later start time for high school students, more teaching assistants in classrooms, and more behavior management staff added to our schools. Our high school students need more sleep. Shifting to a later start time to accommodate their sleep needs would help them mentally, physically, and academically. Teaching assistants make a remarkable difference in the classroom; each elementary teacher should have a TA whose job is to help foster learning for our younger students. Finally, we need to recognize that some

of our children are struggling. Frankly, schools don't have time to debate why, they need to be able to act. Trained behavior management staff who can help a struggling child would benefit not only that child but all of their peers as well. While all of this is expensive, the benefits to our kids would far outweigh the cost.

6. What differentiates you as a candidate and if elected, what will be your top priority during your term?

My informal campaign motto is "It doesn't need to be this hard." I think all School Committee members should commit to doing a lot more listening - to one another, to the Superintendent and her team, and to the community at large. School Committee meetings shouldn't be a place to tune in for drama, snarky comments, or obnoxious behavior. They should be kind of boring. I'm committed to doing my best to bring back the boring! Let's get some work done and leave the drama to social media.

7. Yes/No: I fully support the proposed \$116 million bond referendum to replace the district's three aging elementary schools on one elementary campus.

Yes

Robert Thomas Greene - no response
Edward Lowe - no response
Larry C. Phelps - Opted Out



Be Sure to Vote on Tuesday, November 3, 2026.

EARLY

EARLY VOTING PERIOD
OCTOBER 14 - NOVEMBER 2, 2026

VOTING

HERE

In the 20 days leading up to Election Day, you can vote in person at your town hall. This is a great option if you are unable to vote at your usual polling place on Election Day, or if you have run out of time to request a mail ballot.

CHARLESTOWN TOWN HALL

4540 SOUTH COUNTY TRL.

COUNCIL CHAMBERS

MON - FRI: 8:30 A.M. - 4:30 P.M. EXCEPT HOLIDAYS

*NOV 2 ENDS AT 4:00 P.M.

HOPKINTON TOWN HALL

1 TOWN HOUSE RD

CLERK'S OFFICE

MON - FRI: 9:00 A.M. - 4:00 P.M. EXCEPT HOLIDAYS

*NOV 2 ENDS AT 4:00 P.M.

RICHMOND TOWN HALL

5 RICHMOND TOWNHOUSE RD.

COUNCIL CHAMBERS

MON, WED, THU: 8:30 A.M. - 4:00 P.M.

TUE: 8:30 A.M. - 6:00 P.M.

EXCEPT HOLIDAYS

*NOV 2 ENDS AT 4:00 P.M.



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